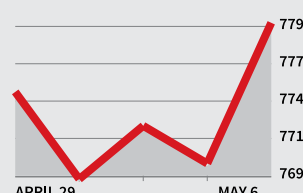


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 77958.52 (+940.73)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	24330.95	+298.15
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.52	+0.61
US Dollar (in ₹)	94.61	-0.67
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	150256.00	+3211
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	249067.00	+8602

BULLION EXIT.

First time in 10 months, central banks sold 30 tonnes of gold in March, led by Turkiye and Russia **p12**



AUDIO UPGRADE.

Samsung Galaxy Buds 4 Pro shines with stellar sound, lightweight form and an improved design **p4**

BENGALURU • CHENNAI • COIMBATORE • HUBBALLI • HYDERABAD • KOCHI • KOLKATA • MADURAI • MALAPPURAM • MANGALURU • MUMBAI • NOIDA • THIRUVANANTHAPURAM • TIRUCHIRAPPALLI • VIJAYAWADA • VISAKHAPATNAM

Regd. TN/ARD/14/2012-2014, RNI No. 55320/94

QUICKLY.

STRATEGIC TIE-UP

India, Vietnam set \$25 b trade target by 2030



New Delhi: India and Vietnam set a \$25-billion annual trade target by 2030, up from \$16 billion last fiscal, and elevated ties to a strategic partnership in a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Vietnamese President To Lam on Wednesday. The leaders also welcomed the signing of an MoU between the Reserve Bank of India and State Bank of Vietnam on financial innovation and digital payments. **p5**

GROWTH GAINS

Services PMI jumps to five-month high in April

New Delhi: India's private services sector saw better activity with the Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) for services rising to a five-month high of 58.8 in April, S&P Global reported on Wednesday. Importantly, inflationary pressure saw some easing during the month. March's headline was 57.5. **p3**

Markets recover as crude oil cools on W. Asia peace hope

CAUTIOUS OPTIMISM. US-Iran seen close to a deal; rupee appreciates; gold, silver rise

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Hopes of peace in West Asia, even if only fragile, were enough to change the mood on Dalal Street on Wednesday, as a single report of a potential US-Iran breakthrough cooled crude prices, nudging investors back into risk assets.

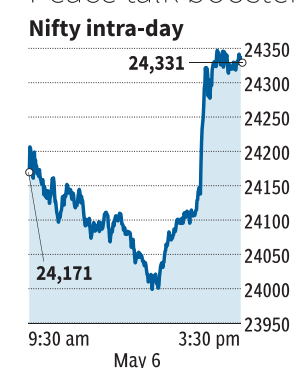
Equities rallied, the rupee strengthened sharply, and the overall market tone turned more optimistic though still hostage to headlines.

Benchmark indices reversed early losses to end over a per cent higher, with the Nifty 50 closing up 298 points at 24,331 and the Sensex rising 941 points to 77,958. Brent crude slipped nearly 7 per cent to around \$102 a barrel, while WTI dropped over 8 per cent to below \$94, marking its steepest two-session fall since the April ceasefire.

US-IRAN THAW?

The trigger was a report from US-based Axios that

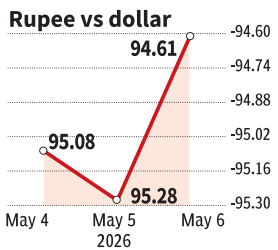
Peace talk booster



said Washington and Tehran are close to a short memorandum aimed at ending hostilities, alongside a pause in escort operations in the Strait of Hormuz, easing fears of supply disruptions.

"The near-term market narrative has shifted meaningfully... if negotiations sustain momentum, the prolonged consolidation phase in the Nifty could begin transitioning into a more durable market re-rating," said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research at Motilal Oswal Financial Services

Yet, beneath the relief



rally, unease lingers. "Who doesn't like buoyant markets? So the going was good today... let's keep our fingers crossed that things remain better tomorrow," said Arun Kejriwal, Founder of Kejriwal Research and Investment Services. He cautioned that oil dynamics remain unpredictable, with producing nations having little incentive to allow prices to fall. "It is one day away from going back," he said.

India VIX, the fear gauge, eased to around 16.7, signalling a moderation in near-term volatility. Vinod Nair,

Head of Research at Geojit Investments, said markets were "driven by easing US-Iran tensions... though the trend remains headline-sensitive," adding that part of the rally was tactical and short-covering led.

RE'S BEST ONE-DAY RISE

The rupee mirrored the shift in sentiment, logging its best single-day gain in nearly a month. It appreciated 67 paise to close at 94.61 per US dollar, moving below the 95 mark on softer crude and improved flows. "The move was supported by easing geopolitical tensions... reducing oil supply risks," said Dipti Chitale of Mecklai Financial Services, citing softer crude, foreign inflows and likely RBI dollar sales.

BULLION RALLIES

Precious metals also rallied sharply on the geopolitical developments, with gold (999 fineness) prices jumping ₹3,224 to ₹1,50,860 per 10 g, and silver prices rising by ₹8,602 to ₹2,49,067 a kg on hopes of a likely end to the hostilities in West Asia.

SpiceJet, Akasa frontrunners to access ECLGS 5.0 for airlines

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi



SpiceJet and Akasa Air are seen as frontrunners to access airline-specific funds under the fifth edition of the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS), industry sources told *businessline*.

On April 13, *businessline* reported that India was expected to cushion the impact of the West Asia crisis on the airline industry by allocating around ₹5,000 crore under a proposed new version of the ECLGS.

On Tuesday, the Union Cabinet approved ECLGS 5.0 to support credit flow of ₹2.55 lakh crore with up to 100 per cent government guarantee for micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), non-MSME sectors and airlines, including a separate ₹5,000 crore allocation for the aviation sector.

The Ministry of Civil Aviation said the scheme will provide 90 per cent credit guarantee coverage to member lending institutions through the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company Ltd to support additional credit extended to air-

IMPROVING CASH FLOW. The scheme offers a seven-year loan tenure, along with an option to convert up to 50 per cent of interest into a funded interest term loan

lines facing liquidity stress due to the West Asia situation.

As per the Ministry, the scheme offers a seven-year loan tenure, along with an option to convert up to 50 per cent of interest into a funded interest term loan, easing immediate repayment pressure and improving cash flows.

ADDITIONAL CREDIT

The scheme will provide additional credit of up to 20 per cent of peak working capital utilised during the fourth quarter of FY26, capped at ₹100 crore.

For airlines, this may extend up to 100 per cent, capped at ₹1,500 crore per borrower, subject to condi-

tions. Speaking to *businessline*, sources said interest rates are expected at 9-10 per cent, along with a moratorium on interest servicing during the initial phase.

Individual airlines may access up to ₹1,000 crore, extendable by another ₹500 crore if the promoters infuse an equivalent amount.

The airline component will run for five years with a two-year extension, while the scheme will be applicable to loans sanctioned up to March 31, 2027.

Sources added that earlier versions of ECLGS supported businesses during Covid, and the current version is expected to aid airlines facing disruptions in routes, costs and operations.

Government and industry to invest equally in Semicon Mission 2.0

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The Centre will retain the *pari passu* model in the upcoming phase of the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM 2.0), signalling a preference for tighter fiscal management even as it doubles down on building a domestic chip ecosystem.

Pari passu, a Latin term meaning 'on equal footing', refers to a funding structure in which government incentives are released in proportion to a company's own capital expenditure.

SKIN IN THE GAME

Under ISM 1.0, the Centre committed to providing 50 per cent fiscal support for project costs, but disbursed



the funds only after firms invested their own money. In effect, public funds move in step with private spending, rather than being front-loaded.

Officials said that by linking subsidies to actual project progress, risks of cost overruns, delays or idle allocations are reduced.

"Because of the *pari passu* model, companies are seriously investing in this sector

and global companies, too, are joining hands with them," a senior official said.

The structure has underwritten the first phase of the mission, launched in 2021 with an outlay of ₹76,000 crore.

As of May 5, 2026, investment commitments totalled ₹1.64 lakh crore, surpassing the original target of ₹1.6-lakh crore, an outcome the government attributes in part to the credibility and discipline imposed by the co-investment model.

CUTTING IMPORTS

The policy is embedded in a broader strategic push to reduce India's dependence on imported semiconductor.

Officials indicated that once domestic fabrication and packaging facilities be-

come fully operational, the government is considering measures to nudge or mandate procurement of 'Made in India' semiconductor chips across sectors. The long-term objective is to build a resilient supply chain.

CAPACITY BUILDING

According to Ashok Chandak, President, India Electronics and Semiconductor Association and SEMI India, ISM 2.0 represents India's transition from creating semiconductor manufacturing capacity to building a full ecosystem.

"The next phase should focus on equipment, materials, specialty chemicals, design-led innovation, IP creation, advanced displays and talent development," he said.

Vijay stakes claim to form govt with Cong support, but no invite from TN Governor

Our Bureau
Chennai

With the initial euphoria of the victory behind them, the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) is now having to learn some political manoeuvring as it tries to get the numbers to form the government in Tamil Nadu.

TVK President C Joseph Vijay on Wednesday met Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Arlekar at the Lok Bhavan and staked claim to form the government by giving a letter.

However, a swearing-in ceremony on Thursday appears unlikely as the Governor did not invite him to form the government, till the time of writing.

The convention is for the Governor to invite the largest party to form the government. It is learnt that the Tamil Nadu Governor has been weighing legal opinions



TVK chief Vijay calling on Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Arlekar (fourth from right) at Lok Bhavan in Chennai on Wednesday **p71**

on whether a TVK government can be sworn in as it does not have the 118-seat majority in the 234-member House.

FULL BACKING

TVK's meeting with the Governor came after the Indian National Congress broke its decades-long association with the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) to extend its full support to Vijay to form the government, adding five seats to the TVK tally.

Senior Congress leaders

met Vijay at the TVK office to personally hand over a letter of support. "Our support shall be conditional upon the TVK keeping out from this alliance any communal forces that do not believe in the Constitution of India," said a statement issued by Girish Chodankar, AICC in-charge for Tamil Nadu.

This alliance — founded on mutual respect, appropriate share, and shared responsibility between the two parties — is not only for the formation of this government, but also for future

elections to the local body organisations, the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha, a Congress statement added.

However, even after adding five seats of Congress to the TVK's tally of 108, it is still short of the magic figure of 118.

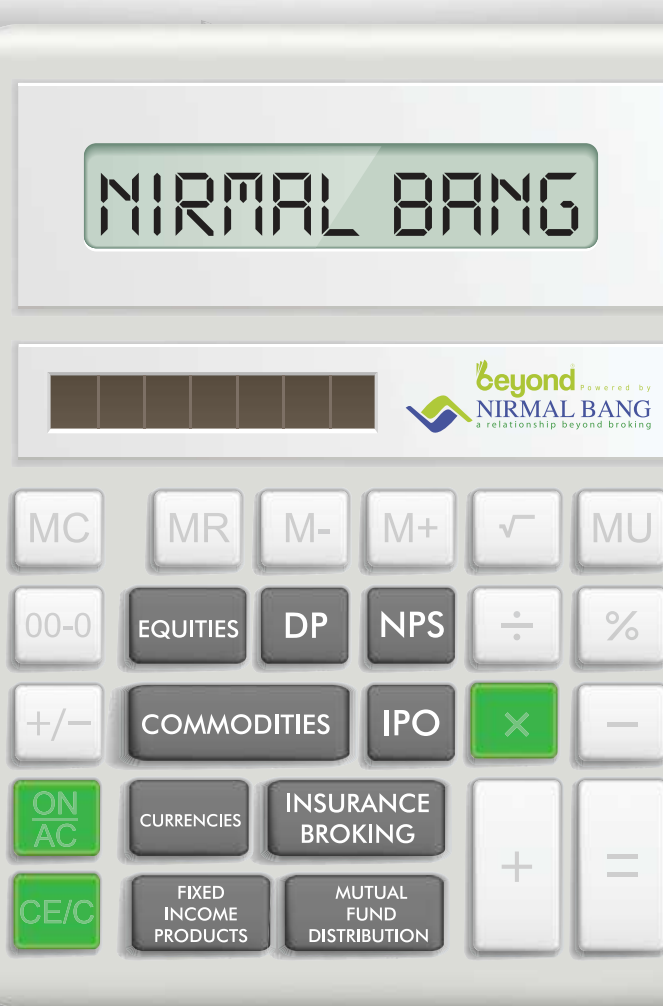
COALITION HOPES

With AIADMK representatives, including Deputy General Secretary KP Munusamy, categorically denying to media persons that they were considering a coalition with TVK, the TVK's hopes now lie with the Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK), the two Communist parties or the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK). With multiple feelers being sent and backroom meetings happening, all eyes are now on when and with whose support Vijay will be able to take oath as the Chief Minister.

ADD. MULTIPLY. DIVERSIFY. ALL IN ONE PLACE.

NIRMAL BANG
a relationship beyond broking

Every investment option you need, on one platform you trust.



EQUITIES | COMMODITIES | CURRENCIES | DP | NB PMS | IPOs | NPS | MTF | PMS & AIF
MUTUAL FUND DISTRIBUTION* | INSURANCE BROKING** | FIXED INCOME PRODUCTS

Disclaimer: NIRMAL BANG SECURITIES PVT LTD: Investment in Securities market are subject to market risks. Read all the related documents carefully before investing. Please read the Do's and Don'ts prescribed by the Commodity Exchange before trading. We do not offer PMS Service for the Commodity segment. Opening of account will not guarantee allotment of shares in IPO. Investors are requested to do their own due diligence before investing in any IPO. The securities quoted are exemplary and are not recommendations. ISSE (Member ID-498): INB011072759, Exchange Registered Member in CDS: NSE MEMBER ID-050911, INB230539139, INF230539139, INF230539139, NSEI Member ID-1087, INB260839138, INF260839138, INF260839138, Single Registration No. IN200025236, PMS Registration No. INP00002981, Research Analyst Registration No: INH000001766, NSDL/CDL: INDP+CDL3 37499, Exchange Member ID: MCX - 66460, NCDEX - 2073, Regd. Office: B-2, 30/1/202, 3rd Floor, Marathi Innova, Off Gangapada Kadam Marg, Lower Panel (W), Mumbai - 400013, Tel: 627380101, Fax: 627380101 | NIRMAL BANG WEALTH PVT LTD: AMFI Registered Mutual Fund Distributor & SIF Distributor (ARN - 111233) | APMI Registered PMS Distributor (APRN02874) Regd. Office: Nirmal Bang Wealth Pvt Ltd, B - 201, Khandeewal House, Poddar Road, Near Poddar Park, Malad (East), Mumbai - 400097, Mutual Fund & SIF investments are subject to market risks. Please read the offer documents carefully before investing. **NIRMAL BANG INSURANCE BROKING PVT LTD: IRDAI Registration No: 795, Insurance is the subject matter of the solicitation. For more details on policy terms, conditions, exclusions, limitations, please refer/read policy brochure carefully before concluding sale.

www.nirmalbang.com



QUICKLY.
Interio by Godrej eyes 25% revenue growth in FY27

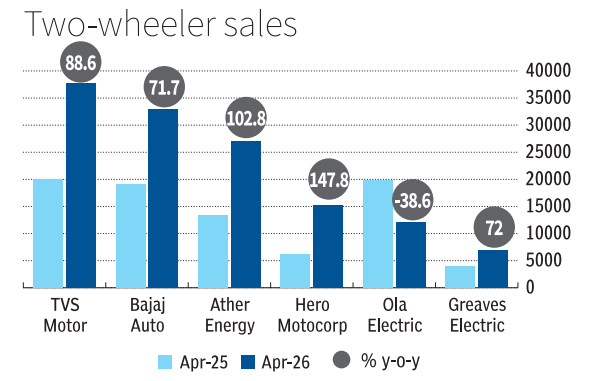
Chennai: Interio by Godrej, the furniture brand from Godrej Enterprises, is aiming to grow its revenues by 25 per cent in FY27, as part of its goal to reach ₹10,000 crore in topline by 2029. The company closed FY26 with revenues of ₹4,000 crore, which was a similar 25 per cent increase from the preceding fiscal. Its topline mix included about 55 per cent from its institutional business where it designs and builds interiors for workspaces, while the remaining 45 per cent came from furniture sales to retail consumers. Speaking at a press conference here, Dev Narayan Sarkar, Senior V-P and Head of Consumer Business, said that there remains significant headroom for growth in the furniture market. “The market has huge potential. People are increasingly spending more time in their homes. The requirement of great furniture is important and growing,” he said. **OUR BUREAU**

Electric PVs , two-wheelers show exponential growth in April: FADA

IN TOP GEAR. In the mass-market segment, Tata Motors leads with 8,543 units, a growth of 77 per cent

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Electric passenger vehicle (PV) retail sales in India grew 75.14 per cent year on year at 23,506 units in April 2026 as compared to 13,421 units in the same month last year, Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA) said on Wednesday. The auto industry body said that the electric PVs now contributed 5.8 per cent (3.7 per cent) to the overall PV market in India. In the mass-market segment, Tata Motors continued to lead the market with 8,543 units (4,822 units) in April, a growth of 77 per cent. Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M) was number two, re-



Source: FADA Research

porting a growth of 64 per cent to 5,413 units (3,310 units), followed by JSW MG Motor India with sales of 5,006 units (3,777 units). Newcomers VinFast and Maruti Suzuki India saw neck and neck with the Vietnam-based EV maker selling 1,232 units and the latter selling 1,231 units, as per the latest data shared by FADA. In the luxury electric PV segment, BMW sold 300 cars (144) in April, followed by Mercedes-Benz India with 104 units (87 units) and Tesla with 43 units.

In the electric two-wheeler (2W) segment, TVS Motor Company leads the market with sales of 37,683 units (19,976 units) in April, a jump of 88.64 per cent. Bajaj Auto follows with registration of 32,898 units (19,162 units), followed by Ather Energy with 27,034 units (13,332 units) and Hero MotoCorp with 15,238 units (6,150 units) during the month. However, Ola Electric reported decline in sales, even though its position remains on fifth. Its sales declined 38.60 per cent to 12,171 units (19,824 units). Overall, the electric 2W retail sales grew around 61 per cent to 1,48,740 units(92,538 units), FADA report indicated. “The EV share in 2Ws moderated to 7.8 per cent in

Bajaj Auto Q4 revenue rises 32% to ₹16,006 crore

Scorecard				(₹ crore)
	Q4FY25	Q4FY26	y-o-y change (%)	
Revenue from operations	12,160	16,006	32	
EBITDA	2,442	3,323	36	
PAT	2,050	2,746	34	

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Bajaj Auto reported a 32 per cent year-on-year rise in revenue from operations to a record ₹16,006 crore for the quarter ended March 31, 2026 (Q4FY26), driven by all-time-high volumes, improved product mix and favourable currency movements. The company's consolidated profit, attributable to its owners, more than doubled to ₹3,661.9 crore in Q4FY26 from ₹1,801.9 crore in Q4FY25, aided by strong operating performance as well as gains linked to the restructuring and consolidation of its KTM-related investment. The broad-based growth was supported by healthy double-digit expansion across domestic motorcycles, electric two-wheelers, three-wheelers and export businesses. The company announced a ₹5,633-crore share buyback at ₹12,000 per share, a premium of about 16 per cent over Bajaj Auto's Wednesday closing price of ₹10,314.60, alongside a dividend of ₹150 per share for FY26, subject to shareholder approval. Together, the proposed buyback and dividend broadly match the company's FY26 standalone profit after tax. Consolidated profit surged 47 per cent to ₹10,744 crore (₹7,325 crore), reflecting the significantly-expanded group footprint following the acquisition of controlling interest in Bajaj Auto International Holdings AG, the parent entity of KTM AG and Bajaj Mobility AG, in November 2025. On a standalone basis, full-year revenue from operations reached a record ₹58,451 crore, up 17 per cent, while standalone profit after tax climbed 21 per cent to ₹9,825 crore. EBITDA for the full year was ₹12,019 crore, up 19 per cent, with margins improving 30 basis points to 20.5 per cent. Total volumes for FY26 crossed the 51-lakh unit mark, the highest ever for the company, up 10 per cent, surpassing the previous peak in FY19. Domestic volumes grew 3 per cent to 28.67 lakh units, while exports expanded 21 per cent to 22.50 lakh units. Commercial vehicle exports were particularly strong, rising 49 per cent. **DRIVING GROWTH** Domestic demand was led by premium motorcycles and the continued scaling of Triumph and KTM partnerships. Bajaj Auto said its premium portfolio gained share within the domestic motorcycle segment, cushioning the impact of softer demand in entry-level commuter bikes.

Cement makers expect sharp demand pick-up due to infrastructure push ahead of the monsoon

Suresh P Iyengar
Mumbai

After a sluggish April, cement makers are betting on a sharp pick-up in demand this month, driven by a push in infrastructure and real estate activity ahead of the monsoon. Last month's slowdown was largely attributed to labour shortages, as workers — particularly from West Bengal — returned home to vote in elections. Early signals in May are encouraging, but recent price hikes of ₹10-20 per 50-kg bag could temper demand in some regions. GETTY IMAGES



NOTHING CONCRETE. Early signals in May are encouraging, but recent price hikes of ₹10-20 per 50-kg bag could temper demand in some regions. GETTY IMAGES

companies increased prices across most regions. With the consistent cost pressure, cement producers will initiate another rise in this month on expectations of revival in demand. Vinod Vaishi, Chief Executive Officer, Ambuja Cements, said given the head-

lines of inflation and weak monsoon, the cement industry may grow at around 5-5.5 per cent in FY27. **COST PRESSURE** The cost pressure has been substantial on the entire industry and the company has targeted to achieve a cost of

₹4,000 a tonne by FY26-end, but it was ₹4,400 a tonne, he said in an analyst call. Since these are fast-moving global situations and dynamics over the energy cost and expected hikes in the fuel and diesel, it will be very difficult to provide any long-term estimates till the time things stabilise over next two-three quarters, he added. Ashutosh Murarka, Cement Analyst, Choice Institutional Equities, said migrant movement impacted construction activity for nearly two-three weeks across certain markets. **BETTER DEMAND** Industry interactions suggest that demand is likely to improve in May ahead of the

monsoon season, with most management commentaries indicating that the April softness was transient in nature, he said. Ravi Singh, Chief Research Officer (Research), Master Capital Services, said labour shortage was also due to the wedding season and workers returning to their villages for pre-monsoon agricultural activities. “Pick-up in demand will be led by institutional and infrastructure segment, while trade dealers are still playing it safe and not stocking up much. Overall, demand in the near term remains soft. Even if volumes recover a bit, rising input costs will keep the pressure on the industry,” he said.

Blue Star posts 3.6% revenue growth in FY26

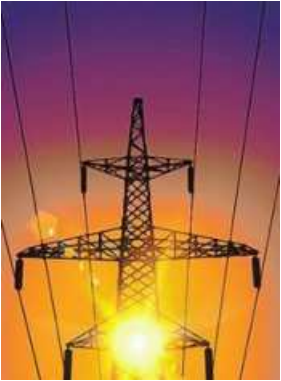
Our Bureau
Mumbai

Blue Star reported a 3.6 per cent rise in consolidated revenue from operations to ₹12,402 crore for FY26, even as net profit declined to ₹527 crore from ₹591 crore in the previous year, weighed down by a one-time exceptional charge of ₹38.83 crore related to new labour codes. The company recorded its highest-ever quarterly revenue in Q4FY26, with revenue from operations at ₹4,072 crore, up 1.3 per cent year on year. Operating profit for the quarter jumped 16.8 per cent to ₹326 crore, with margins improving to 8 per cent (7 per cent).

Power systems biz drives CG Power FY26 profit up 23 per cent, revenue rises 25 per cent

Our Bureau
Chennai

Murugappa Group company CG Power and Industrial Solutions reported a 32 per cent rise in net profit for Q4FY26 at ₹363 crore. The profit was driven by revenue growth and strong order momentum across its industrial and power systems business. Revenue grew 25 per cent and stood at ₹3,442 crore. For FY26, CG Power reported a 23 per cent rise in net profit at ₹1,198 crore. Revenue was ₹12,418 crore, compared to ₹9,909 crore in FY25. On a standalone basis, the net profit of CG Power in Q4FY26 was higher, with a growth of 49 per cent at ₹412 crore (₹275 crore). On a consolidated basis, order intake was at ₹5,335 crore (a 39 per



cent growth) and unexecuted order backlog as of March 2026 was 61 per cent higher at ₹17,107 crore. Order intake for the year was at ₹19,616 crore, a 33 per cent growth. Margin gains in the fiscal driven by strong standalone performance were offset on a consolidated basis by continued investment in the talent

The power systems segment saw a 46% revenue growth at ₹5,138 crore, reflecting strong execution discipline

pool for semiconductor businesses. The industrial systems segment saw a 6 per cent growth in revenue in FY26 despite volatility and rising commodity costs. However, the power systems segment saw a 46 per cent revenue growth at ₹5,138 crore, reflecting strong execution discipline.

KEY EVENTS Among the key events of the year are CG Power bagging an order for supply and servicing of a 765kV Transformer

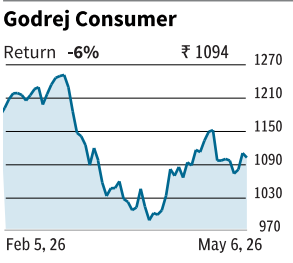
Package 7TR-12- Bulk from the PowerGrid Corporation of India. The company also secured the largest single order of ₹244 crore for the EHV Business from Techno Electric for supply of packaging instrument transformer, circuit breakers and lightning arrestors. CG Semi Private Ltd, a subsidiary of CG Power, unveiled one of India's first end-to-end Outsourced Semiconductor Assembly and Test facility in Sanand, Gujarat, in August 2025. “The G1 facility will operate at a peak capacity of 0.5 million units per day. G2 facility is expected to be completed by CY2026-end,” the company said. “Once operational, G2 will scale up to a capacity of approximately 14.5 million units per day,” it added.

Godrej Consumer Q4 profit rises 10% to ₹452 cr

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Godrej Consumer Products (GCP), on Wednesday, crossed ₹15,000 crore in annual revenue for the first time, with FY26 consolidated revenue from operations rising 8.4 per cent to ₹15,177.9 crore — a scale milestone that signals its evolution from a largely India-centric FMCG company into a broader emerging-markets consumer platform. The board declared an interim dividend of ₹5 per share (500 per cent on face value) for FY26. GCP also approved a fresh five-year term for Managing Director and CEO Sudhir Sitapati beginning October 18, 2026, while veteran industrialist Nidhi Godrej announced his retirement from the board effective August 7 — marking a broader transition from promoter-era stewardship

toward a more institutionalised operating structure. For Q4FY26, consolidated net profit rose 9.7 per cent to ₹451.8 crore, while revenue from operations increased 11 per cent to ₹3,900.4 crore. “Our focus on category development, cost discipline and operational excellence continues to translate into improving performance,” said Sitapati, in an earnings call. **ARGENTINA IMPACT** For FY26, however, net profit remained largely flat at ₹1,861.5 crore, while profit before tax declined 3.1 per cent to ₹2,590.2 crore. The company said Argentina's hyperinflationary accounting impact increased reported revenue by ₹78.24 crore, but reduced profit by ₹46.19 crore during the year. “We have already seen parts of the portfolio that have started to significantly outstrip growth driven by in-



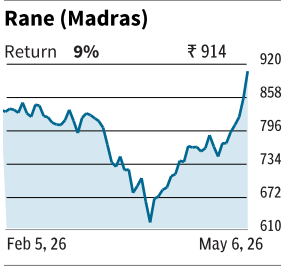
vestments,” said Sitapati, adding, “We expect this to happen across the portfolio.” The sharpest shift in the numbers came from Africa, where revenue rose 23.1 per cent to ₹3,154.5 crore in FY26, sharply outpacing India growth of 7.9 per cent and offsetting weakness in Indonesia, where revenue declined 2.5 per cent to ₹1,822.6 crore. India continued to remain the company's largest market, contributing ₹9,474.1 crore in FY26 revenue. But the numbers also suggest the India business is increasingly

behaving like a stable cash-generating FMCG engine rather than a hyper-growth market. **KEY SEGMENT** Home care was the key growth driver, with 12 per cent value growth. Personal care, however, remained subdued with a 3 per cent growth, impacted by weak soaps category and some seasonal factors. Sitapati said home care will structurally outpace personal care, going forward. Indonesia remained the pressure point in the portfolio. Apart from revenue decline, segment profit from Indonesia also slipped 2.4 per cent to ₹480.6 crore from ₹492.3 crore in FY25, weakening one of GCP's historically high-margin businesses and partly explaining why strong revenue growth did not fully translate into earnings expansion.

Rane (Madras) profit soars 5x in Q4

Our Bureau
Chennai

Rane (Madras), a part of the Chennai-based Rane Group of Companies, a leading auto component group, reported over five times increase in consolidated net profit to ₹37 crore for fourth quarter ended March 31, 2026, compared with ₹6.5 crore in Q4FY25. Total revenue was up 16 per cent to ₹1,052 crore (₹905 crore). The Q4FY25 included non-recurring charges of ₹11 crore in merger-related exceptional expenses and a ₹6-crore tax impact from MAT credit reversals, the company noted. Sales to do-



mestic original equipment customers grew 11 per cent mainly due to higher offtake across vehicle segments. Sales to international customers increased 27 per cent, supported by strong offtake of steering products. Sales to Indian aftermarket customers experienced a 16 per cent growth, a statement said. During Q4FY26, the company incurred capital expenditure of ₹53 crore, taking the full-year FY26 capex to ₹191 crore. Investments were directed primarily towards capacity expansion in steering, engine and brake components. In FY26, net profit more than doubled to ₹108 crore (₹38 crore). Rev-

enue was up 13 per cent to ₹3,863 crore (₹3,406 crore).

FINAL DIVIDEND The company's board has recommended a final dividend of ₹16 per equity share on the paid-up capital of 2,76,37,137 of ₹10 each. During Q4FY26, the company secured new business wins with an annualised sales of ₹33 crore, taking the full-year FY26 order wins with an annualised sales value of ₹712 crore, across domestic OEM and international customers. The company is cautiously optimistic about the demand environment in FY27. “While domestic demand remains stable, the company continues to monitor external risks that could influence the operating environment. Factors such as geopolitical developments, volatility in crude oil and commodity prices, exchange-rate movements and potential supply-chain disruptions could affect production costs,” it said.

Arvind Fashions back in black in Q4 on denim-led growth

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad

Arvind Fashions, a leading denim and casual wear player, reported a consolidated net profit of ₹47 crore in Q4FY26, reversing a ₹93-crore loss in the same quarter last year, driven by strong like-to-like growth and robust performance across direct channels and core apparel brands. Revenue rose about 15 per cent year on year to ₹1,365 crore, supported by a 7.8 per cent like-to-like growth and expansion in direct-to-consumer business, reflecting sustained demand in the denim and casual wear segment. The board recommended a final dividend of ₹1.60 per share for FY26, subject to shareholder approval. For the full year, it posted 14 per cent revenue growth to ₹5,266 crore, while net profit stood at ₹123 crore versus a ₹36-crore loss in FY25, in-



dicating improved operating leverage and stronger branded execution. Managing Director and CEO, Amisha Jain, said FY26 reflected “quality, consistency and compounding strength of earnings,” driven by brand momentum and capital efficiency gains. She added that growth will be driven by expansion into adjacent categories, deeper brand investments and scaling of direct channels, supported by technology, AI-led initiatives and supply chain improvements. On a comparable basis, profit from continuing operations rose 56 per cent to ₹42 crore, excluding one-off impacts from the previous year.

LG India ramps up India exports

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

LG Electronics India aims to increase exports from India this year with its growing focus on “Make-in-India”. The consumer durable major has also expanded its affordable premium product range — the Essential Series and expects to sell over one million units of this range this year. Sanjay Chitkara, Co-CEO, LG Electronics India, told *businessline*, “Our exports strategy continues to be a critical part of our Global South strategy, and our focus is to increase our export capabilities. Currently, exports are roughly around 7 per cent of our revenues. We are now starting to export our Essential Series, which was launched in October last year. Exports of the Essential Series are expected to touch 22 countries across Asia, West Asia and Africa in 2026.” The company, on Wednesday, unveiled its 2026 Home Appliances Range across



both affordable-premium and premium segments. While it is expanding its Essential Series, it also launched new premium products. At the launch event, Young Min Hwang, Vice-President and Division Leader - Home Solutions, LG Electronics India, said, “Designed specifically for everyday Indian living, the Essential Series addresses key local needs such as power fluctuation, water availability, and practical storage requirements. Following the strong response from the consumer and our trade partner in 2026, we are expanding the Essential Series with broader

capacity options and across more product categories to serve even more households. The Essential Series are expected to sell over one million units this year.” **NEW PRODUCTS** In terms of premium end, the company has introduced new products across categories including Make in India side-by-side refrigerators extending capacity up to 790 litres. “We were earlier importing such large capacities for the Indian market, but now we have begun manufacturing some of these products in India,” he explained. On raw material cost pressures, Chitkara said, “The current geopolitical situation has created some cost pressures in terms of commodity prices, logistics cost and some currency movements. We have seen some fluctuations in copper and aluminium prices. We are trying to manage these pressures through cost optimisation and more localisation of our products.”

businessline.

Disclaimer: Readers are requested to verify & make appropriate enquiries to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHING PVT LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

TECH DIGEST.

Google Translate turns 20

In 2006, Google Translate began with the mission to help people understand one another, regardless of the language they speak. Translate now features pronunciation practice, where users can master their delivery on the Translate app for Android. You can already tap “ask” and “understand” to provide additional context and receive alternatives. Translate works for almost 250 languages and more than 60,000 potential language pairs, including endangered and indigenous languages. Live translate helps you get a quick translation when travelling, like better understanding a local speaking to you or listening to a tour guide. English to Spanish remains the most common go-to language pair in Translate but other common language pairs include English to Indonesian, Portuguese, Arabic and Turkish. English to three Indian languages — Hindi, Bengali and Malayalam — round out the list of picks of language translations in India.

OnePlus Pad 4 launched

OnePlus unveiled its latest flagship tablet, the OnePlus Pad 4 recently. The OnePlus Pad 4 combines the Snapdragon® 8 Elite Gen 5 platform with a stunning 33.53 cm, 13.2-inch 3.4K display and a massive 13,380 mAh battery. The OnePlus Pad 4 delivers powerful, PC-level

performance in a sleek, all-in-one form. The display has 144 Hz refresh rate for ultra-smooth visuals, an immersive eight-speaker setup with spatial audio and Dolby Vision support, 80W fast charging for minimal downtime and a large VC cooling system that ensures consistently high performance across demanding tasks. The OnePlus Pad 4 is built for professionals and creators who demand both high performance and multitasking capabilities and blends powerful hardware with smarter software experiences, making it great for work and entertainment. The OnePlus Pad 4 is available starting ₹54,999 with sales commencing on May 5.

POCO introduces C81 Series

POCO has introduced its entry-level C81 series, comprising C81 and C81x, aimed at everyday users seeking large displays and



long battery life at a budget price. Both phones feature HD+ screens (6.9-inch on the C81, 6.88-inch on the C81x) with adaptive 120 Hz

refresh rates. The C81 comes with LPDDR4X RAM and UFS 2.2 storage, and runs Android 16 with Xiaomi HyperOS 3. It is slated to receive four OS updates and six years of security updates. The C81x also uses LPDDR4X RAM, with a shorter support cycle of two OS updates and four years of security updates. Both devices are built around large batteries claimed to last up to two days, with 15 W charging and 7.5 W reverse charging supported. On the camera front, the C81 carries a 13 MP dual rear setup, while the C81x has a single 13 MP rear camera. Both include 8 MP front cameras and support 1080 p video recording, along with standard modes such as HDR and Night. The phones feature side-mounted fingerprint sensors, IP52-rated splash resistance, Bluetooth 5.2, dual-band wi-fi and a 3.5mm headphone jack. Storage starts at 64 GB, expandable up to 2 TB via microSD. The POCO C81x (3 GB/64 GB) is priced ₹9,999, while the C81 (4 GB/64 GB) is priced ₹10,999.

India leads in usage of ChatGPT Images 2.0

India has emerged as the largest user base for ChatGPT Images 2.0, according to OpenAI. The image model allows users to generate



visuals from text prompts, including stylised portraits, posters and layouts with embedded text. It supports multilingual input and can produce multiple outputs from a single prompt. In India, usage is centred on creative formats such as anime-style portraits, cinematic headshots, tarot cards, mock newspaper front pages and fashion mood boards. Activity is largely driven by young users experimenting with online identity and visual styles. The model is also capable of handling more detailed instructions and generating structured visuals, including layouts that require readable text. In India, a few of the trends include Universal Lighting (studio-style portrait effects), Headshot (professional profile images), Anime (manga-style avatars), Spring (pastel, seasonal visuals), Style Me (AI-generated fashion looks), Flash (paparazzi-style imagery), Fantasy Newspaper (fictional front pages), Enhance (photo restoration), Tarot (card-style visuals) and Blueprint (architecture and design concepts).

Siddharth Mathew Cherian

POCO has been on a roll in recent years, consistently filling out its lineup of high-performance mid-rangers. Following the launch of the X8 series earlier this year with the Pro Max and Pro, I’ve been using the POCO X8 Pro as my primary device to see how it holds up. Here’s how it fared.

DESIGN

The POCO X8 Pro adopts a clean, monolithic aesthetic. Built with an aluminium frame and a frosted glass rear, the device remains relatively pocketable despite its footprint, weighing in at 201.47 g with a slim 8.38 mm profile. That frosted finish provides a matte-like texture, offering a secure one-handed grip that avoids the slipperiness typical of high-gloss glass panels. The review unit came in White, though Black and Green options are also available. This specific colourway is paired with red accents around the camera modules and the power button, a subtle touch of flair that breaks up the otherwise minimalist white finish.

DISPLAY

The POCO X8 Pro centres around a 6.59-inch AMOLED display, achieving a 94.1 per cent screen-to-body ratio with nearly invisible bezels. The 2756 × 1268 resolution and 460 PPI pixel density ensure sharp detail, while HDR10+ support and a peak brightness of 3,500 nits (2,000 nits in HBM) offer excellent outdoor legibility. For durability, the panel is protected by Corning Gorilla Glass 7i. The display delivers impressive colour fidelity. While streaming content like the Hindi series *Glory* on Netflix, the panel maintained natural skin tones without the aggressive oversaturation often found in this segment along with good contrast levels. Whether handling the high-contrast lighting of ringside fight scenes or the detailed set-pieces between characters, the visual experience remained balanced and immersive.

SOUND

The POCO X8 Pro is equipped with dual stereo speakers, featuring Dolby Atmos support. In testing, the audio profile remained well-balanced; tracks like Avicii’s *The Nights* and *Naadan Parinde* from *Rockstar* demonstrated a clear separation between vocals and instrumentals. Even at higher volumes, the output remained composed without distorting. This tuning carries over effectively into gaming. Environmental cues, such as footsteps and gunshots, are rendered with enough clarity to provide a distinct sense of space, making the device a strong



WELL TRIMMED. The POCO X8 Pro adopts a clean, monolithic aesthetic with with red accents around the camera modules and the power button BUOY GHOSH

performer on the audio front.

CAMERA

The POCO X8 Pro uses a Sony IMX882 sensor for its main camera. The rear setup includes a 50 MP main lens and an 8 MP secondary lens, while the front has a 20 MP camera for selfies. For video, you can shoot in 4K at 60 fps from the back and 1080p at 60 fps from the front. Pictures from the dual camera setup turned out decent. Day time images aren’t too saturated, and the contrast is good enough to give the photos a nice natural look. Details were retained up to 2x while zooming, post which it does tend to get over sharpened or lose out on image details. Night-time shots were clear with little noise, making them good enough to post straight to social media. The 20 MP front camera also did a solid job, keeping a good amount of detail in selfies.

PERFORMANCE

The POCO X8 Pro is powered by the MediaTek Dimensity 8500-Ultra chipset, built on a 4 nm process. To keep thermals in check, it uses a 5300 mm² 3D ICELOOP cooling system. In AnTuTu benchmarks, the device delivered a score of 2,009,775. This places it as a very capable mid-ranger, sitting just slightly behind the Galaxy S25 FE (2,019,182).



The contrast is good enough



Day time images aren’t too saturated

Gaming on BGMI was a smooth experience, maintaining a steady 80+ FPS on balanced graphics. The heat dissipation worked well; while the phone started to feel a bit warm after an hour of play, there was no noticeable throttling or frame drops. The device comes in two configurations — 8 GB+256 GB and 12 GB+256 GB — and runs on Android 16 with HyperOS 3.0. POCO has also promised four years of Android OS upgrades and six years of security updates.

On the software side, everything runs smoothly without any major hiccups. Besides Google Gemini and circle to search, which are quite

refined, AI features like AI writing, speech-to-text and translation need more refinement. However, the amount of pre-installed bloatware — like Block puzzle game and Dropping Bubbles — is a bit high, with about four to six of these games appearing out of the box installed. While they are easy enough to uninstall, it’s an extra step for users who just want to get straight to downloading and playing their favourite AAA titles without having to search through many app screens.

BATTERY

The POCO X8 Pro is equipped with a 6,500 mAh battery that supports

100 W fast charging, with the brick included in the box. It also features 27 W reverse charging and compatibility with 100 W PPS/PD standards. In daily use, the phone easily lasted a full day. It averaged 7.5 to 8 hours of screen-on time with a mix of calls, browsing and occasional camera use. When it did run low, the 100 W charger took the device from 0 to 100 per cent in roughly 50–55 minutes.

VERDICT

At ₹32,999, the POCO X8 Pro is a well-positioned sibling to the Pro Max. It stands out as a strong gaming contender, though it’s held back by mid-range camera performance and pre-installed bloatware that titters the software experience. While rivals such as the Realme 16 Pro 5G, iQOO Z10 5G and OnePlus Nord 6 offer a more balanced all-round experience, the POCO X8 Pro remains a great choice if your priority is a good performance gaming smartphone.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹32,999
Pros: Great performance, good display and decent battery life
Cons: Average cameras, bloatware

Hits the right notes

SAMSUNG GALAXY BUDS 4 PRO. Stellar sound, lightweight form and an improved design

Ashwin Rajagopalan

TWS wireless bluetooth earbuds have become so ubiquitous that they have almost been commoditised. Aside from Apple and Samsung, the other players in the premium end of the segment include Bose, Sony and Sennheiser but most of the action is in the sub 10K or 5K market. Samsung’s Galaxy Buds 4 Pro are the brand’s shiny new flagship earbuds and take over from last year’s Buds 3 Pro that divided Samsung loyalists with their design and overall performance. Over the years, brand loyalty in this segment has become an extension of the smartphone brands that customers choose. That brings us to the obvious question — are the all-new Buds 4 Pro the best premium option for Android users?

DESIGN

The Galaxy Buds 4 Pro are among the best looking premium earbuds right now. I wasn’t a fan of the design route Samsung took for last year’s Buds 3 Pro. The Buds 4 Pro are a welcome departure. While they stick with the same transparent lid, I prefer the horizontal layout for the case that is not just practical but also looks more premium. I found it easier to remove and dock these buds even with sweaty hands. The flat, brushed metal stems are a step up from its predecessor. They never came off even on days I pushed harder at the gym or during vigorous headbanging when I got carried away with Def Leppard’s *Hysteria* album, a day after I caught them live in Bengaluru. The stems come with a bunch of controls, no surprises here. These buds are also geared for some of your adventures, thanks to their IP57 rating.

SOUND

The biggest upgrade for the Buds 4



LEVELLED UP. The Buds feature an enhanced two-way speaker system with a 11 mm woofer and a 5.4 mm planar tweeter ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

Pro is in the sound department. While Samsung and Apple have levelled up with their soundstage, this is the area where serious music afi-

cionados drift towards brands such as Bose and Sony for key two reasons — active noise cancellation and the overall soundstage. Samsung



The Buds sit comfortably in ear ASHWIN RAJAGOPALAN

loyalists might not need to step out of their Samsung garden any more for superior sound. Samsung is playing up the set-up that includes a wider woofer with nearly 20 per cent more speaker area. They feature an enhanced two-way speaker system with a 11 mm woofer and a 5.4 mm planar tweeter. Expect a bass-forward soundstage and great details at 50-60 per cent volume levels that is the ultimate test for any pair of headphones or earbuds. These buds support 24-bit/96 kHz audio via Samsung Seamless Codec for high-res sound.

I enjoyed listening to the high-energy house beats on *Call Me Up* by Petit Biscuit and Eugenie. The Buds 4 Pro enhanced the acoustic-electric guitar sounds on Goo Goo Dolls’ *Misery*. The companion app allows you to tweak the settings with a 9-band equaliser. The Buds 4 Pro are not just among the best earbuds in the sound department but also score on the noise cancellation front. The best spaces to test the ANC (active noise cancellation) capabilities for any earbuds are noisy flight cabins or the gym; the Buds 4 Pro did a great job in these environments during our tests. Callers could hear me clearly even

from the gym, suggesting that the six in-built mics did a great job with picking up my voice and muffling other external sounds.

BATTERY LIFE

The Buds 4 Pro deliver the same performance as their predecessor — about 30 hours in total with ANC off and 26 hours with ANC. Our results matched Samsung’s claims. We would have liked to see an improvement on the battery life front though. The buds offer the convenience of wireless charging, a standard feature with TWS earbuds at this price point. The case charges up in a little over an hour, a quick five minute charge provides about an hour of music playback. While battery life is acceptable, this is an area where some of Samsung’s rivals have pulled ahead.

VERDICT

Samsung’s Galaxy Buds 4 Pro are among the best premium earbuds you can buy now. While some of the audio features, such as real time translation and 360 audio with head tracking, are exclusive for Samsung devices, there are quite a few features that Android and iOS users can access via the companion spp. These buds improve on three key fronts — design, acoustics and noise cancellation — but deliver the same battery life as last year’s Buds 3 Pro. They are easy to recommend for Samsung smartphone owners who are willing to pay a premium for stellar sound.

● SNAPSHOT

Price: ₹22,999
Pros: Premium design, active noise cancellation, acoustics
Cons: Not all features available for non-Samsung devices, similar battery life as predecessor

India, Vietnam eye \$25 billion bilateral trade target by 2030

STRATEGIC MOVE. 13 MoUs signed on digital payments, rare earths

Our Bureau
New Delhi

India and Vietnam set a \$25 billion annual trade target by 2030, up from \$16 billion last fiscal, and elevated ties to an enhanced comprehensive strategic partnership in a meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Vietnamese President To Lam on Wednesday.

The talks focused on areas including trade, investments, banking, defence, agriculture, health, ICT and critical minerals with 13 MoUs signed in diverse areas, such as digital payments and cooperation in rare earth elements and emerging technologies.

“We have taken several important decisions today to take our bilateral trade to \$25 billion by 2030. The MoU between our drug authorities will now increase access to Indian medicines in Vietnam. The export of Indian agricultural, fisheries and animal products to Vietnam is also going to be easier. Soon, Vietnam will taste India’s grapes and pomegranates, and we will taste Vietnam’s pomelos,” Modi said in his speech at the joint press briefing with Lam after their bilateral talks.

The Vietnamese President is on a three-day visit to India and is accompanied by a



EXPANDING TIES. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Vietnam President To Lam during the joint press briefing in New Delhi ANI

business delegation. The leaders welcomed the signing of the MoU between the Reserve Bank of India and the State Bank of Vietnam on financial innovation and digital payments. “They agreed to promote linkages for retail payment platforms via QR codes that would facilitate tourism and businesses of both sides,” per a joint statement.

The two leaders also agreed to update the India-ASEAN trade agreement by the year-end, Modi noted. “This will give new impetus to trade and investment between India and all ASEAN countries. New initiatives in critical minerals, rare earths and energy cooperation will ensure the economic security and supply chain resilience of both our countries,” he said.

TWO-WAY FLOWS

On investments, the leaders agreed to encourage greater

two-way flows to further strengthen India-Vietnam economic ties, especially in the fields of high technology, transport, manufacturing, logistics, renewable energy, smart agriculture, electric vehicles and information technology, healthcare, agriculture and agro-processing, aquaculture, tourism and hospitality, per a joint statement issued by the two sides.

“They also agreed to strengthen the linkages between the two countries’ start-up ecosystems and encourage substantive cooperation among innovation centres,” the statement highlighted.

The two countries would bring about a stronger change in economic cooperation, trade cooperation and investment cooperation through value chain connectivity, removing barriers and expanding market access, the Vietnamese President said.

Indian industry plans to invest \$20 billion in US

Our Bureau
New Delhi

Indian industry, led by pharmaceutical companies, shared plans of investing \$20.5 billion in the US at the 2026 SelectUSA Investment Summit, reinforcing the growing role of Indian companies as investors and partners in the US economy, per a statement issued by the US Mission in India on Wednesday.

“Under President Donald Trump’s leadership investment is flowing back into the US at record levels! Indian companies plan to invest over \$20.5 billion in various sectors including tech, manufacturing and pharmaceuticals. This includes the 12 Indian companies who announced \$1.1 billion in investments just today,” said Sergio Gor, US Ambassador to India, in a social media post.

As much as \$19.1 billion of the promised \$20.5 billion would come from Indian pharmaceutical companies, with Sun Pharma alone accounting for \$11.75 billion with its planned acquisition of the New Jersey-based Organon & Co.

Participating companies include Aurobindo Pharma Ltd, Biocon Group, Cipla Ltd, Dr Reddy’s Laboratories Ltd, Glenmark Pharmaceuticals Ltd, Granules India Ltd, Jubilant Group, Lupin Ltd, Sun Pharmaceutical Industries Ltd, Piramal Pharma



Ltd, and Zydus Lifesciences Ltd, the statement noted.

12 NEW INVESTMENTS

The 12 new investments worth \$1.1 billion formally announced at SelectUSA 2026 include four in manufacturing.

These are the Abhyuday Group’s (Ahmedabad) over \$900 million investments across five US sites, creating 1,500 American jobs; Jindal Pipe and Jindal Tubular USA’s investment of \$87 million to expand in Texas and Mississippi, creating 140 jobs; Jivo Wellness’ (Delhi) investment of \$15 million, creating 50 direct jobs and up to 150 indirect jobs, and Polyhose Inc investment of \$2 million in Los Angeles to support the US shipbuilding industry.

Six investment commitments are from technology, AI and digital infrastructure companies. While Sterilite Technologies Ltd (Mumbai) will invest \$100 million, creating up to 500 jobs and supporting AI and telecom infrastructure, investments from the other companies are between \$1.5 million and \$7.5 million.

Actual ODI outflow jumps 84% in 2 years

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Actual overseas direct investment (ODI) outflows at the end of fiscal year 2025-26 surged nearly 84 per cent over FY24, data from the Finance Ministry showed. Singapore topped in terms of receipts, while a combination of financial, insurance and business services accounted for 45 per cent in total outflows.

According to the data, actual ODI outflows reached over \$26.7 billion at the end of FY26 as compared to \$24.2 billion in FY25 and around \$14.5 billion in FY24. In FY26, out of actual outflows, equity investment by Indian entities was over \$18.6 billion, while loans accounted for over \$8 billion.

During the entire fiscal year, September saw the highest outflows with over \$4 billion while November accounted for the lowest with over \$0.8 billion.

TOP NATIONS

During FY26, Singapore attracted most outflows with over \$7.6 billion, followed by the US with over \$4 billion and Mauritius with over \$2.4 billion.

In terms of sectors, ‘Financial, insurance and business services’ got the maximum with over \$11 billion, followed by manufacturing at over \$4.6 billion and ‘wholesale, retail trade, restaurants and hotels’ at \$3 billion.

Vaibhav Luthra, Tax Part-

Overseas direct investment

Top countries	Amount (\$ billion)	Top sector	Amount (\$ billion)
Singapore	7.63	Financial, insurance and business services	11.38
USA	4.08	Manufacturing	4.69
UAE	3.1	Wholesale, retail trade, restaurants and hotels	2.92
Mauritius	2.47	Transport, storage and communication services	2.57
UK	1.57	Agriculture and mining	1.67

Source: Finance Ministry

ner at EY India, said FY26 deal-level data suggested the headline outbound investment number reflects structural consolidation by India Inc. First, the surge is concentrated.

MAJOR GROUPS

The five major Indian headquarter groups alone account for over \$8 billion of FY26’s \$46.9 billion financial commitment, with capital largely deployed through Singapore and the Netherlands holding platforms to recapitalise existing overseas operations.

Second, guarantees made up close to 41 per cent of FY26 commitment, broadly matching fresh equity. This points to Indian groups leveraging their balance sheet strength to support the funding needs of overseas subsidiaries and backing them up on their performance validation.

And third, “the more telling structural shift is the \$3.1 billion invested through IFSC GIFT City by key groups, signalling a clear mi-

gration of treasury, aircraft-leasing, and global financial services functions,” he said. Mayank Arora, Director – Regulatory at Nangia Global, listed another factor for increase in ODI. He said it could be attributed to steady weakening of the rupee.

Exploring investment opportunity abroad at a time when the rupee is steadily falling ensures a guaranteed minimum return on repatriation of funds back to India.

“The most important factor, however, is the maturing of Indian industry, which is now confident enough to explore beyond its shores to new lands. Going forward, we should expect more ODI, which should, however be matched with corresponding FDI inflows as well to manage forex and ensure development,” he said.

ODI refers to investments made by Indian entities in a foreign country. In this form of investment, Indian companies and individuals can enter into a joint venture or have their wholly owned subsidiary in a different country.



BORROWER(S) AND GENERAL PUBLIC ARE HEREBY NOTIFIED THAT BELOW MENTIONED BORROWERS HAVE FAILED TO REPAY OR PROVIDE THE REQUIRED MARGIN DESPITE REPEATED NOTICES. DUE TO SAID REASON, GOLD OFFERED BY BORROWER(S) AS SECURITY FOR REPAYMENT OF LOAN WILL BE AUCTIONED ON *AS IS WHERE IS BASIS*. SUBJECT TO FOLLOWING TERMS:

- SCAN QR CODE TO ACCESS THE FULL DETAILS OF THE PUBLIC NOTICE. (Gold Detail & Gross weight).
- COMPLETE BIDDER TERMS ARE AVAILABLE AT <http://172.30.1.235:3000/?WOUB2QG9WU> 3. BIDDERS MUST DEPOSIT EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT(EMD) OF 25,000/- BY ONLINE TRANSFER ON OR BEFORE AUCTION;
- PERSONAL ATTENDANCE AT AUCTION VENUE AT 10AM, IS MANDATORY WITH VALID PROOF OF IDENTITY & ADDRESS.

ANY CHANGE IN AUCTION DATE WILL BE DISPLAYED AT AUCTION CENTER. SUBMISSION OF BID IS CONSTRUED AS DEEMED ACCEPTANCE OF ABOVE TERMS. FOR ANY ENQUIRIES, CONTACT wecare@bajajfinserv.in

GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

BAJAJ FINANCE LIMITED ("BFL"):
REGISTERED OFFICE: MUMBAI - PUNE ROAD, AKURDI, PUNE 411035



Worthy proposal

Brokerage net worth should be linked to number of clients

The surge in retail equity investors and the manifold increase in cash and derivatives trading since the pandemic has ramped up the risks faced by stakeholders — namely, stockbrokers, investors looking for quick returns and the markets ecosystem. The existing rules of the Securities and Exchange Board of India on net worth requirements for stockbrokers do not adequately cover risks in this regard.



In a welcome move, the regulator has proposed an improved formula on net worth requirements. Spelt out in a consultation paper, the formula addresses higher risk arising from aggressive client acquisition by the broking fraternity. Existing regulations lay down that brokers must maintain a minimum net worth, which is the higher of the base net worth or variable net worth. Base net worth is currently ₹1 crore for trading members and the variable net worth is fixed at 10 per cent of average daily cash balances of clients across exchanges, computed over the previous six months. However, with the new rules requiring brokers to move clients' funds to clearing members, the average daily cash balance with brokers has dropped. The variable net worth norm is not in line with the operational risks faced by them. The paper instead proposes that the variable net worth be linked to daily average credit balance and the number of clients a brokerage has. Substituting cash balance with credit balance is a good idea, since the latter is a better marker of a broker's volume of business.

Linking brokers' net worth to number of clients appears aimed at deterring brokers from trying to grow their client base too rapidly. SEBI proposes a variable net worth of ₹50 lakh for brokers with direct clients between 10,000 and 50,000 and ₹50 lakh for every additional 50,000 clients. If the clients are acquired and serviced through authorised persons (AP), brokers must maintain higher reserves. For instance, if 50,000 clients are acquired through APs, the variable net worth requirement increases to ₹2.25 crore. The regulator would be right in doing so since supervision and compliance requirements are lower for APs. They are not directly supervised by SEBI, but are registered with the stockbrokers, who take the onus of monitoring their business. SEBI's proposals suggest that there could be higher default risk in clients acquired through APs. While larger stockbrokers can easily meet the additional reserve requirement, smaller ones may run up against a liquidity crunch.

The proposals will also help slow down entry of new equity investors. The number of unique investors registered with the NSE has increased from 3.1 crore in March 2020 to 12.9 crore in March 2026, at a compound annual growth of 26 per cent every year. Stockbrokers and the APs have driven the entry of new investors in recent years. By linking variable net worth to number of clients, SEBI seems keen to rein in the frenetic pace of client growth. This is desirable to suck out market froth.

POCKET: The Summer of '26

RAVIKANTH



Remedies for digital payment frauds

KEEPING VIGIL.Static safeguards, targeting discrete acts of fraud, will only spur fraudsters to probe other vulnerabilities

GETTYIMAGES/STOCKPHOTO



BENI CHUGH
SARADA MAHESH

The recent rise in fraud in the financial ecosystem is a cause for concern. The RBI's 'Report on Trends and Progress of Banking in India', notes that the value of fraudulent activities in banking operations has risen from ₹11,261 crore in 2023-24 to ₹34,771 crore in 2024-25.

Apart from the obvious monetary losses, frauds cause a crisis of confidence and trust among customers that threatens the momentum of financial inclusion and the growth of the sector.

Considering these drastic and cascading effects of frauds, the RBI is deliberating important policy interventions to address frauds in digital payments.

First, the RBI's draft framework on limiting customer liability in digital transactions ("liability framework") recognises authorised push payments (APP) as a customer risk and proposes a redress mechanism for it. APPs comprise payment transactions that the customer may have authorised willingly but unintentionally.

This includes social engineering plays where fraudsters manipulate customers to either share transaction credentials enabling the fraudster to transfer monetary sums to themselves or directly transfer monetary sums to the fraudster. The liability framework proposes a one-time compensation of up to ₹25,000 or 80 per cent of the transaction value

for victims of low-value APP fraud.

Further, the compensation is conceived as a low-burden mechanism, a de facto guarantee to remedy bona fide APP losses of up to ₹50,000.

Interestingly, this compensation is dispensed by the financial system. Banks vet complaints, establish their veracity and the RBI offers the compensation. It may reduce the proclivity of the customers to approach the legal system to seek redress for low-value APP fraud, thus, shielding the legal system from becoming overwhelmed by low-value, high-volume complaints that are expensive to investigate.

The one-time compensation, though illustrative of the central bank's resolve to make good to victims, does not offer any enduring solution for the customer who gets defrauded repeatedly. Its low-effort nature also does not have the effect of disciplining the customer by accounting for their role in enabling the fraud, which is characteristic of a good remedial measure. In addition to providing a remedy for APP frauds, the RBI has also proposed preventative safeguards to curb APP fraud. The RBI's discussion paper titled 'Exploring safeguards in digital payments to curb frauds' suggests four such measures: a lag in fulfilment of transactions above

Chase system-level resilience instead of individual fraud categories. This requires diverse financial and non-financial actors such as telecom operators and e-commerce entities to work together

₹10,000; an additional authentication system of trusted persons for older customers; commensuration of credit to accounts based on a relationship of trust established with the bank; and a customer-led kill-switch for digital payments.

These safeguards underline the RBI's 'stop and think' approach, encouraging customers to pause and reconsider the riskiness of the transaction at hand.

However, the application of these interventions is anchored in static demographic categories of age, physical condition or the sophistication of the remitter. These indicators alone may not be useful for detecting fraud.

RECHARACTERISING THE ISSUE OF FRAUD

Conventionally, fraud has been characterised as a static issue where bad actors exploit the gaps in the system and/or use their comparative operational advantage to cheat people out of money. Typically, static systems do not learn from or react to changes in the environment in which they operate.

However, fraudsters are known to improvise in response to policy developments. If policies make it difficult for fraudsters to cheat 70-year-old citizens, they will focus on the 68-year-olds. Put simply, static preventative safeguards do not terminate frauds, they only incentivise the fraudster to identify other exploitable vulnerabilities. This ever-evolving nature of fraud offers four lessons for designing fraud prevention policies:

First, static rules will be gamed. Fraud prevention needs to be reimaged as a system of continuous recalibration instead of a system rooted in 'static'

The great white collar wipeout?

From offices to battlefields, machines are taking over faster than expected, leaving millions of workers exposed

THE WIDER ANGLE.



PARAN BALAKRISHNAN

Remember the lamplighters, the men who, as darkness fell in cities like London and Paris, walked along the streets lighting one lamp after another? They vanished without a trace, replaced by centrally controlled electrical systems that made their work obsolete.

We've lived through technological upheavals before in recent decades and yet employment has climbed. Armies of banking employees disappeared from behind counters, but they were usually able to find other jobs in that era of steady growth. Technology displaced roles, but expanding economies absorbed the shock.

Today, though, we appear to have reached a crunch era compounded by unstable geopolitical forces. There's the Russia-Ukraine War, the Persian Gulf conflict and Donald Trump's America-first unpredictability. And it's all happening as change approaches at unprecedented speed.

Consider agentic AI, a term coined only in 2024 to describe systems that can decide what needs to be done and do it. Only months ago, many people were first hearing of tools like Anthropic's

Claude and realising how fast and easy they are to use. At the same time, some of the people building these systems are issuing stark warnings.

"No-one knows what will happen next" but "some areas are, like, totally gone," says OPENAI chief Sam Altman. Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei says AI could drive unemployment among knowledge workers as high as 20 per cent globally in fields such as coding, finance and law, and eliminate large swathes of entry-level white-collar jobs. That matters because those roles are traditional middle-class gateways. As AI completes complex tasks in minutes that once took skilled teams weeks, the fear is this wave could decimate the middle class.

JOBS AT RISK

At Infosys, Nandan Nilekani says companies will need top-to-bottom reinvention. Cognizant has announced 15,000 layoffs, mostly in India. At Salesforce, 4,000 customer service roles have been cut after AI began handling half of all support interactions. Across sectors, the pattern is clear: small teams can now do work that once required many engineers and managers.

For India, this carries a deeper risk. IT services, outsourcing and back-office operations created vast numbers of mid-skill, entry-level white-collar jobs. If AI now handles much of this work, companies hire fewer people. Surveys



AI. Jobs threat looming GETTY IMAGES

suggest 17 per cent of companies have already laid off contact centre workers because of AI. These are large-volume roles, and AI doesn't just replace them in one company but across thousands, leaving far fewer alternative employers. For a country that needs to generate jobs at scale, that creates both a volume problem and a skills mismatch, with demand rising for highly skilled workers even as entry-level roles disappear.

Companies such as Coinbase, Atlassian and HP have all announced AI-linked layoffs. Freshworks is cutting 11 per cent of staff as AI writes more than half of its code. Duolingo is reducing headcount as AI takes over translation. Education firm Chegg has cut 22 per cent of its workforce after losing users to AI tools. At IBM and elsewhere, AI systems are replacing HR and administrative jobs. For India, there's an added concern that its role as

a global outsourcing hub could weaken if work is automated at source rather than sent overseas.

Elon Musk warns AI and robotics could eventually replace all jobs altogether. Yet not everyone agrees. Meta chief scientist Yann LeCun argues new technologies historically create as many opportunities as they destroy.

It's clear almost every industry, even the military, will be altered beyond recognition. This is already visible in Ukraine, where drones and robots are being used to attack troops, with efforts under way to make them fully autonomous. China, too, is changing warfare rules. At the Malan Airbase in Xinjiang, it's developing unmanned aircraft, meaning future ace pilots may be engaged in something closer to video games.

India's Border Security Force, meanwhile, has set up drone laboratories, while in Gwalior it has tied up with IITs to train students. The army now runs training schools where even lower-level soldiers are taught to operate and defend against drones.

All of this points to a moment that feels different from earlier technological shifts. Now, with geopolitical instability and AI advances colliding, the transition may be far sharper. For India, the challenge is greater because of the sheer numbers entering the workforce and the shrinking pool of roles that once absorbed them.

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Left needs recalibration

The Indian Left has lost its sole bastion in Kerala. Its decline must not be mistaken for a final verdict, as there can be no obituaries for ideas whose moral questions remain unanswered. Inequality still widens, work grows more precarious, and excesses of unbridled growth is heavy burden. These are the unfinished business of our times. What appears today as a weakening of the Left may, in fact, be a moment of incubation. If capitalism continues to deliver prosperity without inclusion, it must summon a resistance different from old rigid orthodoxy. A renewed Left could emerge as a pragmatic force: one that partners with markets yet

disciplines their excesses, embracing innovation while insisting on equity, that protects growth but humanises it more.

The Left is not fading into irrelevance but needs to be reshaping it: quietly, persistently, and perhaps more effectively than before.

R Narayanan
Navi Mumbai

Reforming WTO

It is with reference to the article 'Can the WTO get back on track?' (May 6). WTO faces significant challenges — including the inability to conclude the Doha Development Agenda, and a shift towards bilateral and regional trade deals. These issues stem from a struggling consensus-based model,

power imbalances favouring developed nations and stalled negotiations on agriculture and subsidies.

Unless urgent reforms are undertaken, the global trading system may soon witness the demise of the institution once deemed indispensable.

P Victor Selvaraj
Palayamkottai (TN)

Handling gold

This refers to the Editorial "Gold rush" (May 6). Notwithstanding the geopolitical tensions, the growing imports of gold driven by sentimental consumer attachment more towards cultural, religious and investment motives will impact the

economy in the long run. With large scale stock piling, the intrinsic value of bullion has not been properly explored. The gold monetisation scheme 2015, allowing individuals to deposit gold in the form of jewellery and coins with attached incentives of nominal interest on deposits and capital gain tax exemptions, enabling banks to monetise the underlying gold assets, could not gain momentum due lower interest rates offered on deposits. As aptly suggested, by augmenting additional assaying infrastructure and offering more tax slops, the over 30,000 tonnes of gold lying idle with the households can be remonetised.

Sitaram Popuri
Bengaluru

Industrial policy

Refers to "New governments often bring fresh vision for industrial policy, says CII chief Rajiv Memani" (May 6). Political factors often shape industrial policy by influencing project approvals, regulatory clarity, and investor confidence. However, political uncertainty can discourage private investment and distort industrial planning. Governments must ensure continuity in contracts, stable frameworks, diversify risk across sectors, transparent dispute resolution, and predictable taxation.

O Prasada Rao
Hyderabad

QUICKLY.

Mindspace REIT raises ₹500 crore via debentures



Mumbai: Mindspace Business Parks REIT has raised ₹500 crore through a 10-year non-convertible debenture issuance, fully subscribed by a leading Indian life insurer. The bonds carry a 7.63 per cent annual coupon with AAA/Stable ratings from Crisil and ICRA. Proceeds will primarily refinance existing debt, supporting stable, long-term financial planning. The move aligns with the REIT's strategy to lock in fixed rates, reduce exposure to interest volatility and broaden its investor base. CEO Ramesh Nair highlighted investor confidence, while CFO Preeti Chheda emphasised improved cash flow stability. Total capital raised by Mindspace REIT now stands at approximately ₹16,400 crore. **OUR BUREAU**

Muthoot Finance hits ₹1.5 lakh crore market cap

Kochi: Demonstrating consistent growth and strong financial performance, the market capitalisation of Muthoot Finance has surged from approximately ₹6,000 crore in 2011 to over ₹1.5 lakh crore, an increase of more than 25 times. Over the past five years, the company's stock price has more than doubled, highlighting sustained investor confidence and robust growth momentum, a press release issued here said. The company has played a pivotal role in unlocking the value of idle household gold and channelling it into productive economic use, serving over 2.5 lakh customers daily. At the consolidated level, the group's branch network has expanded to over 7,500 locations, with nearly 70 per cent situated in semi-urban and rural areas. **OUR BUREAU**

L&T stock falls as dip in profit, softer FY27 outlook weigh on sentiment

SHAKY GROUND. Order inflows remain resilient, but brokerages flag near-term growth visibility

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Larsen & Toubro shares fell nearly 4 per cent in early trade and closed in red on Wednesday after its March quarter results showed a decline in profit and a cautious near-term outlook, which appeared to unsettle investors despite steady revenue growth. The stock dropped to an intraday low of ₹3,900 but recovered to close at ₹4,008.50, down 1.13 per cent from the previous close of ₹4,054.50. The company reported an 11 per cent year-on-year rise in consolidated revenue for Q4FY26 at ₹82,762 crore. However, net profit declined 3 per cent to ₹5,326 crore, indicating margin pressures

and a mixed operating performance during the quarter.

GROWTH OUTLOOK Brokerages highlighted that while order-inflows remained resilient, near-term growth visibility has moderated. Motilal Oswal said the company's Lakshya 2031 strategy, which includes investments in new-age areas, could be return-dilutive in the near term. The brokerage revised its estimates to factor in lower order-inflows and execution in FY27, along with expected divestments of Hyderabad Metro and Nabha Power by Q1FY27. It added that execution in H1FY27 is likely to remain soft due to supply chain disruptions. The brokerage now has a SOTP-based target price of ₹4,550.



THUMBS UP. Analysts are bullish on L&T's Lakshya 2031 strategy, which includes investments in new-age areas such as data centres, electronics and semiconductors

Global brokerage Bernstein maintained an Outperform rating with a target price of ₹4,637, noting that order-inflows continued to beat expectations despite a high base. However, it flagged that revenue missed estimates due to geopolitical

disruptions and weakness in the domestic water segment, while margins came in slightly below expectations. Jefferies retained its Buy rating and raised the target price to ₹4,885 from ₹4,500, citing long-term growth visibility under the Lakshya

2031 roadmap. It highlighted plans to invest in data centres, electronics and semiconductors, along with a potential real estate IPO as part of the company's value creation strategy.

CAUTIOUS CALLS On the other hand, Nomura downgraded the stock to Neutral and cut its target price to ₹3,940, citing subdued Q4 performance and a less optimistic outlook on FY27 order-inflows. It also reduced its earnings estimates for FY27 and FY28 by 8 per cent. HSBC maintained a Hold rating while lowering its target price to ₹3,800, noting that although order-inflows and revenue remained strong, the overall outlook reflects near-term challenges.

Motilal Oswal AMC gets PFRDA nod to launch pension fund

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Motilal Oswal Asset Management Company has received approval from the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) to act as a Sponsor of Pension Fund under the National Pension System (NPS). The AMC will set up a separate pension fund entity that will act as an investment manager, overseeing the NPS contribution of subscribers and managing pension assets in accordance with the PFRDA Act, 2013, and applicable regulations. Motilal Oswal AMC will



Prateek Agrawal, MD and CEO, Motilal Oswal AMC

undertake the necessary formalities including obtaining the Certificate of Registration and executing key agreements such as the Investment Management Agreement with the NPS Trust, along with further arrangements with other custodians, intermediaries and

parties. Upon completion, it will commence full-scale operations to act as a Sponsor of Pension Fund under the NPS. Prateek Agrawal, MD and CEO, said as the financial ecosystem evolves, the need for disciplined, retirement investment and planning is becoming critical for long-term financial security. As Indians shift their financial habits moving from a saver to an investor mindset, NPS inflows have also been growing steadily and the fund house will bring a long-term investment approach focused on delivering consistent performance for investors to build sustainable retirement wealth.

OMCs, paint stocks rally as oil prices fall sharply

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Shares of oil marketing companies and paint manufacturers climbed on Wednesday amid a steep decline in oil prices, which fell below the \$100 per barrel mark. The stock of HPCL jumped 6.89 per cent, BPCL climbed 5.12 per cent and IOC went up 4.22 per cent on the BSE. Among paint manufacturers, shares of Indigo Paints climbed 3.77 per cent, Asian Paints rallied 3.56 per cent, Shalimar Paints advanced 2.33 per cent and Berger Paints went up 1.67 per cent.

Mutual funds accelerate launch of new passive investment products

Our Bureau
Mumbai

With early signs of recovery in the equity markets, mutual funds are rushing to launch passive products which will benefit the most on revival of key indices. SBI Mutual Fund will launch two new exchange traded funds Nifty200 Value 30 ETF and Nifty Smallcap 250 ETF. Both the schemes will open for subscription on May 7. The SBI Nifty200 Value 30 ETF aims to track the performance of 30 companies selected from the Nifty 200

based on value parameters such as earnings-to-price ratio, book value-to-price ratio, Sales to Price ratio and Dividend Yield. DP Singh, Joint CEO, SBI Funds Management, said the ETF launches broaden the fund house's equity passive suite and enhance the solution set available to investors and distributors, addressing distinct portfolio needs based on fundamentally screened stocks to access to the long-term growth potential of the small-cap segment. **GROWW ETF LAUNCH** Groww Mutual Fund has launched ETF on Nifty

Private Bank index. The ETF aims to provide investors with a transparent and rules-based way to gain exposure to India's private banking segment. Over the past decade, private banks' share of total deposits has increased from 21 per cent to 38 per cent, indicating sustained competitive positioning within the sector. The NFO opened on Wednesday. The Nifty Private Bank index comprises 10 private sector banks selected based on liquidity, market capitalisation, and other eligibility criteria, and follows a free-float market capitalisation weighting methodology.

Investor group urges SEC to scrutinise SpaceX IPO filing

Reuters

An investor group, which advises union pension funds, urged Wall Street's leading watchdog on Wednesday to scrutinise SpaceX's disclosures as the rocketmaker embarks on a planned record-breaking public listing. It also raised founder Elon Musk's tenure in the Trump administration as a potential conflict for regulators reviewing the company's disclosures. SpaceX is expected to launch an initial public offering (IPO) this year at a possible valuation of \$1.75 trillion, raising about \$75 billion. That would be the biggest listing on record and could help CEO Musk become history's first trillionaire. SOC Investment Group wrote to Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) chairman Paul Atkins and



commissioners Hester Peirce and Mark Uyeda "to raise concerns over the accuracy and reliability of financials" that SpaceX will file.

REGISTRATION DOC The group said it was waiting for the publication of SpaceX's registration statement, a document which is currently confidential, excerpts of which were reviewed by Reuters. "We are specifically concerned that SpaceX's IPO will expose numerous investors — many unwillingly — to a company whose value may decline once its financial disclosures can be inde-

pendently assessed and verified," the group wrote. An SEC spokesperson declined to comment on a specific company. SpaceX and Musk did not immediately respond to requests for comment. SOC says members of its affiliates participate in pension plans with more than \$250 billion in assets. It has previously called on shareholders to vote against directors at companies including Musk's automaker Tesla. For SpaceX, in which it holds no shares, SOC's concerns include auditor independence, transactions between other companies Musk controls and issues including goodwill impairment and how SpaceX recognises revenue. SOC asked what measures had been taken to make sure staff could review SpaceX's disclosures independently and "without fear of political retribution".

Bagmane REIT IPO fully subscribed on Day 2

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The initial public offer (IPO) of Blackstone-backed Bagmane Prime Office REIT got fully subscribed on the second day of bidding on Wednesday. The ₹3,405-crore IPO received bids for 32,997 crore units against 14.79 crore units on offer, translating into 2.23 times subscription, according to NSE data. The category for other investors fetched 3.83 times, while the portion for institutional investors got subscribed 90 per cent. Bagmane Prime Office REIT has secured about ₹1,150 crore from anchor investors. The public issue will conclude on May 7. The price band has been fixed at ₹95-100 per unit. The IPO has a fresh issue of units aggregating up to ₹2,390 crore and an offer for sale of units worth up to ₹1,015 crore by the selling unitholder.

Embassy Developments resumes normal trading after NCLAT quashes case

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Embassy Developments' shares resumed trading on the BSE and NSE on Wednesday after the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) overturned the insolvency proceedings against the Mumbai-listed real estate developer. Both the BSE and the NSE placed the stock under restriction between the NCLT order in early December 2025 and the NCLAT ruling on May 4. The NCLAT passed its order on May 4, setting aside the earlier admission of insolvency and quashing the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process in its entirety. The shares have also exited the additional surveillance measure framework that had been imposed alongside the IBC classification.

The developer said its business operations, project execution and growth plans remain unaffected by the proceedings. **STRONGEST SALES** The legal resolution comes as Embassy Developments reported its strongest sales year-to-date. The company recorded pre-sales of approximately ₹4,631 crore in FY26, up 128 per cent year on year. Q4 alone delivered pre-sales of ₹2,632 crore — the highest in its history — while full-year collections stood at ₹1,721 crore. During the quarter, two new launches — Embassy Citadel in Worli, Mumbai, and Embassy Verde 2 in Bengaluru — together generated pre-sales of approximately ₹1,385 crore. The company has also secured RERA registration for Phase I of Embassy Serenity in Alibaug, with a launch planned for Q1-FY27.

BROKER'S CALL.

Elara Securities

SOBHA (BUY) Target: ₹2,500 CMP: ₹1,447.80 Sobha reported Q4 pre-sales of ₹2,040 crore, up 11 per cent y-o-y, supported by about 1.3 million sq ft of volume, with Bengaluru contributing 51 per cent, followed by NCR at about 30 per cent and Kerala at about 13 per cent. Q4 momentum was aided by the late-quarter launch of Sobha Rivana (Greater Noida; about 2.5 million sq ft (msf)), which clocked in ₹500 crore of bookings (about 25 per cent of Phase 1) despite a compressed launch window alongside steady sustenance sales across key markets. Overall, FY26 pre-sales stood at ₹8,100 crore, up 30 per cent y-o-y, driven by 6 msf of launches across nine projects and healthy traction in existing inventory, with Bengaluru at 55 per cent and NCR at 30 per cent, anchoring growth. The management targets about 30 per cent pre-sales growth, supported by about 10 msf of launches with a GDV of about ₹15,000 crore and ₹12,000-13,000 crore of inventory, implying ₹27,000-28,000 crore of pipeline for FY27. OCF guidance stands at ₹2,000 crore, up about 22 per cent. Q1-FY27 is off to a strong start, led by Sobha Crescent (Gurugram; ₹1,100 crore booked, about 50 per cent sold in the first month), while Hoskote Phase 1 (5.3 msf with a GDV of ₹7,000 crore; about 50 per cent release) is near launch-ready. The stock price implies a >30 per cent discount to our March 2027E NAV. We raise our pre-sales by up to 23 per cent during FY27-28E while retaining our SOTP-based TP to ₹2,500.

Macquaries

ADITYA BIRLA CAPITAL (OUTPERFORM) Target: ₹415 CMP: ₹369.25 Aditya Birla Capital (standalone)'s Q4 PAT rose 19 per cent y-o-y to ₹780 crore, in line with estimates. Higher-than-expected opex (cost-to-income at 35 per cent vs 33 per cent MQE) was offset by lower credit costs (1 per cent vs 1.2 per cent expected). RoA improved 6 bps q-o-q to 2.3 per cent. AUM growth was healthy at 27 per cent, driven by personal loans (+38 per cent) and unsecured business loans (+47 per cent). Credit cost fell 19 bps q-o-q to a five-year low of 1 per cent, supported by a broad-based 20-bps q-o-q decline in GNPA. The management expects credit costs to remain range-bound despite higher unsecured exposure, aided by a largely collateral-backed portfolio (about 72 per cent of the book) and limited impact from the West Asia conflict to date. NIM fell 4 bps quarter on quarter due to competitive pressure and MTM losses, but should recover as personal and unsecured loans (about 23 per cent of the book) scale-up and a 2-3 per cent rise in mix should drive a 25-30 bps margin uplift over the next few quarters, supporting a RoA target of 2.5 per cent by FY27-end. Aditya Birla Sun Life Insurance reported Q4 VNB and APE growth of 14 per cent, both above expectations. VNB margins improved 20 bps y-o-y. The management targets VNB margins of 18-20 per cent in FY27 and APE growth of 20 per cent over the next three years. Maintain Outperform: Our top pick in the NBFC space.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: blmarketwatch@gmail.com

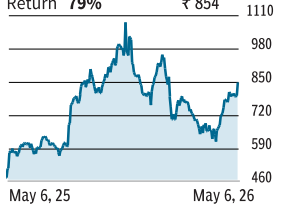
TODAY'S PICK.

HBL Engineering (₹854.90): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The short-term outlook is bullish for HBL Engineering. The stock surged 7 per cent on Wednesday and closed on a strong note. Prior to this rise, it has formed a good base around ₹800. This rise confirms an inverted head and shoulder pattern on the chart. The neckline support of this pattern is at ₹833. Moving average cross overs on the daily chart also strengthens the bullish case. HBL Engineering share price can rise to ₹930-940 in the next few weeks. Traders can buy HBL Engineering shares at ₹855. Accumulate on dips at ₹846. Keep the stop-loss at ₹815

HBL Engineering



initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹865 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹880. Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹890 and ₹910 when the price touches ₹905 and ₹920 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹930. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

24467 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
24400	24320	24600	24750	Go long now and at 24420. Keep the stop-loss at 24370

₹796 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
790	782	804	812	Wait for dips. Go long at 792. Keep the stop-loss at 789

₹1170 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1165	1160	1175	1195	Go long only above 1175. Keep the stop-loss at 1165

₹311 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
309	307	314	318	Take fresh shorts below 309 with a stop-loss at 310

₹281 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
278	275	286	289	Go long on dips at 279. Stop-loss can be kept at 277

₹1439 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1425	1410	1455	1475	Take fresh longs above 1455. Keep the stop-loss at 1445

₹1099 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1085	1070	1120	1140	Go long now and at 1080. Keep the stop-loss at 1070

₹2436 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2410	2370	2455	2500	Go long on a break above 2455. Keep the stop-loss at 2445

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					
	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
HDFC Bank	796.55	80.92	15.48	10.92	
ICICI Bank	1279.50	43.96	15.81	8.20	
State Bank	1096.00	32.66	11.69	4.08	
Axis Bank	1294.20	21.58	15.15	3.33	
Bharti Airtel	1833.70	18.47	30.16	5.04	
M&M	3300.80	17.54	24.28	2.64	
Int'lGlobeAvi	4520.20	13.90	54.43	0.92	
Bajaj Finance	980.75	12.92	31.57	2.35	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	1004.10	12.12	23.57	1.26	
Eternal Ltd.	256.10	11.91	67.13	1.05	
Asian Paints	2519.00	8.77	61.80	1.02	
Maruti Suzuki	13722.00	8.47	29.39	1.61	
Kotak Bank	376.60	8.43	19.42	2.48	
Tata Motors PV	358.15	8.22	48.71	0.67	
Tata Steel	215.47	7.48	29.49	1.60	
Trent Ltd.	4289.80	7.47	88.59	0.85	
Sun Pharma	1850.20	6.79	40.53	1.76	
Bajaj Auto	10319.00	6.60	32.46	1.02	
Dr Reddys Lab	1311.00	5.29	19.81	0.72	
Bajaj Finserv	1836.10	5.22	14.94	0.95	
Adani Enter	2540.30	4.89	32.98	0.65	
JSW Steel	1273.30	4.27	40.10	1.07	
Bharat Elec	439.20	3.79	53.80	1.48	
Cipla	1364.40	3.77	24.31	0.69	
Adani Ports	1748.30	3.75	31.51	1.16	
SBI Life	1859.00	3.70	75.48	0.75	
Grasim Ind	2914.80	3.59	20.94	0.99	
UltraTech Cement	12093.00	3.36	43.52	1.28	
HDFC Life	606.35	2.87	68.41	0.58	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	2352.40	2.85	102.75	0.74	
Max Healthcare	1015.90	2.51	69.66	0.68	
Tech Mahindra	1466.70	2.01	29.90	0.83	
TCS	2435.40	1.80	17.82	2.23	
NestleIndia	1486.10	1.30	81.90	0.95	
Eicher Motors	7310.50	0.27	37.43	0.90	
Tata Consumer/Product	1153.50	0.24	77.39	0.67	
Appolo Hosp	7760.50	-0.26	59.80	0.72	
Wipro	199.12	-0.41	15.74	0.51	
Coal India	470.20	-1.19	9.33	0.96	
Titan	4359.60	-1.26	81.21	1.61	
ITC	310.70	-1.58	18.80	2.68	
Hind Unilever	2317.10	-1.99	51.45	1.84	
HCL Tech	1189.10	-2.55	19.38	1.12	
Hindalco	1045.80	-2.81	14.62	1.36	
PowerGrid Corp	315.95	-3.46	18.93	1.28	
NTPC	394.85	-3.93	15.42	1.68	
ONGC	280.80	-7.75	7.86	0.98	
Infosys	1167.20	-8.33	16.06	3.87	
L&T	4008.50	-11.78	80.53	4.22	
Reliance Ind	1437.90	-37.85	20.32	8.70	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▲ 1,064.15 pts.

	Close(₹)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Tata Motors Cv	429.75	136.88	96.10	3.54
Samvardmotheresoninternat	127.41	89.58	36.95	2.22
Bpcl	314.05	88.96	5.54	2.51
Cholamandlamin&Fin	1711.90	65.89	271.87	2.89
Indian Oilcorp	148.21	64.02	5.68	2.18
Vedanta	316.40	59.96	7.80	2.12
Tvs Motor Cmp .	3617.90	55.36	56.29	3.35
Pidlittind	1421.50	50.17	62.52	1.74
Indian Hotels Co.	666.15	45.49	43.81	2.30
Bank Of Baroda	270.30	36.14	7.12	1.97
Canara Bank	138.04	35.50	6.80	1.83
Macrotech Developers .	949.15	32.87	27.64	1.05
AvenueSuper	4432.20	30.55	97.11	2.57
Power Finance	643.90	28.77	4.59	2.66
Hindus Zinc	634.60	28.58	19.39	1.08
Union Bank	168.75	27.33	6.63	1.28
MuthootFin	3533.60	26.40	16.39	1.47
Cummins India	5324.50	24.60	65.84	2.83
Torrent Pharma	4358.30	24.57	64.92	1.79
Ambuja Cements	446.90	23.76	20.10	1.07
Punjab Natl Bank	110.18	22.29	7.08	1.50
DF	609.60	22.27	34.08	1.54
AdaniGreenEnergy	1353.00	20.44	112.16	1.79
Bosch	36645.00	18.98	39.21	1.25
Zyduslifesciences	938.80	18.75	18.79	0.92
Divis Lab	6702.00	18.30	71.77	1.85
1000 Holdings	100.00	17.48	13.13	1.31
Gail (India)	165.88	15.08	12.66	1.76
Rural Elec	299.10	9.52	5.80	1.77
HindustanAeronautics	4626.90	8.84	34.78	3.46
Hyundai Motor India	1839.90	7.00	25.82	1.03
2000 Holdings	289.58	5.52	2.82	1.26
Indian Railway Finance Corp	106.74	5.22	19.91	0.85
Shree Cement	24975.00	4.91	50.17	1.32
Ltmitrade	431.06	4.51	25.68	1.58
Tata Capital	328.50	4.51	28.51	0.56
Gp Power & Ind Sol	828.90	3.87	117.66	2.24
India Steel	324.12	3.24	12.82	1.94
Tata Power	344.25	2.94	28.82	2.92
Mazagon Dock	2644.50	2.38	38.71	0.79
Siemens	3841.80	-1.20	86.29	1.34
Adani Energy Solutions .	1407.30	-1.25	70.65	1.92
Solar Industries	15740.00	-1.22	93.29	1.51
Godrej Consumer	840.00	-0.40	61.09	1.02
Adani Power	2221.91	-0.81	34.06	3.73
Varun Beverages .	508.95	-10.62	53.63	2.74
Britannia Ind	5783.00	-11.73	57.64	2.68
United Spirits .	1290.30	-21.10	54.56	1.50
Abd India	7182.00	-21.54	90.25	1.48
Ptcs Services India	3185.80	-27.86	96.04	1.11

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Crude oil slumps below \$100 a barrel



London: Crude oil prices extended declines on Wednesday, slumping to two-week lows after a Pakistani source said the United States and Iran were nearing an initial peace deal. Brent crude futures fell 9.2 per cent to \$99.80 a barrel by 1042 GMT, dropping below \$100 for the first time since April 22. US WTI lost 10.6 per cent to \$91.48. REUTERS

Copper climbs on US-Iran peace deal hopes

London: Copper prices extended gains, touching their highest in nearly two weeks, on hopes that the US and Iran are close to a deal to end the war in the Middle East. Benchmark three-month copper on the London Metal Exchange rose 1.8 per cent to \$13,366 a tonne by 0930 GMT. Aluminium prices shed 0.9 per cent to \$3,557.50. Zinc climbed 1.9 per cent to \$3,433 while tin jumped by 6.2 per cent to \$52,800. REUTERS

Palm oil tumbles on weak crude oil



Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures tumbled close to 3 per cent as crude oil and Chicago soyoil prices fell. The benchmark palm oil contract for July delivery on the BMD slid 2.82 per cent to 4,577 ringgits (\$1,176.16) a tonne. REUTERS

Kerala Agri Varsity, VST Tillers Tractors in pact for joint research

Our Bureau

Kochi

The Kerala Agricultural University (KAU) has signed an MoU with VST Tillers Tractors Ltd to collaborate on research, product validation, performance testing, extension activities and the promotion of farm mechanisation in Kerala.

The partnership aims to strengthen industry-academia ties in agricultural engineering by combining VST's technological expertise with KAU's research, teaching and extension capabilities.

JOINT PROJECTS

The agreement will enable joint projects, testing and validation of tractors and farm machinery, training programmes, student research and farmer-focused extension initiatives. As part of the collaboration, VST will

Central banks turned gold net sellers in March

KEY OFFLOADERS. Led by Türkiye and Russia, central banks sold a net of nearly 30 tonnes of gold, offsetting purchases by other banks

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

For the first time in 10 months, central banks turned net sellers of gold in March, data from the World Gold Council (WGC) showed.

Led by Türkiye and Russia, central banks sold a net of nearly 30 tonnes of gold, offsetting purchases by other banks worldwide, according to Marissa Salim, Senior Research Lead, Asia Pacific region of WGC.

Türkiye sold 60 tonnes of gold and Russia 6 tonnes in March, while data from the State Oil Fund of Azerbaijan showed net sales of 22 tonnes in the first quarter this year.

The National Bank of Poland continued purchasing gold, turning out to be the biggest buyer. It bought 11 tonnes.

The Polish bank has been aggressively expanding its

gold reserves for several years.

It has been a consistent net purchaser of gold for over three years now.

The National Bank of Poland has significantly accelerated the buying pace in the past 12-18 months. It is now the world's leading central bank gold buyer.

CHINA BUYS FOR 17TH MONTH

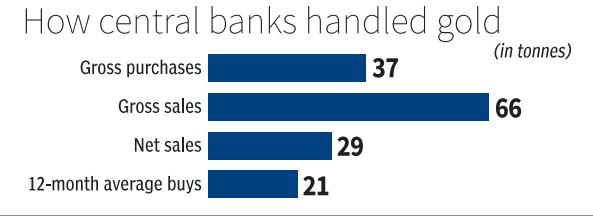
Another consistent buyer, the People's Bank of China, continued its gold purchase spree for the 17th month in a row.

In March, it picked up 5 tonnes.

Among others, the Central Bank of Uzbekistan bought 9 tonnes, and the National Bank of Kazakhstan 6 tonnes.

Joining the top buyers of the yellow metal in March were Guatemala and the Czech Republic, which bought two tonnes each.

Türkiye sold part of its



Source: World Gold Council

gold reserves (60 tonnes) for foreign exchange and liquidity purposes.

Ankara has so far sold 79

tonnes of gold from its reserves. In addition, the Central Bank of the Republic of Türkiye swapped 80 tonnes

of gold to manage liquidity.

Experts said that unlike other central banks that hold gold as a long-term passive reserve, the Turkish central bank uses gold as an active macro-financial buffer.

Russia sold 6 tonnes of gold, mainly since it relies on the precious metal to cover its budget deficits. Analysts said selling gold provided a solution to inject liquidity into the economy.

NOT SURPRISING

Central banks turning net sellers should not be surprising as countries such as Turkey, Russia, Poland, Azerbaijan and Kazakhstan use it to defend their currencies, manage budget deficits, rebalance investment portfolios and tackle domestic inflation.

After soaring to a record high of \$5,608 an ounce on January 29, gold dropped over 15 per cent to around \$4,675 an ounce currently.

The precious metal, which

has been rallying since 2024, is up over 7 per cent this year, despite shedding its gains.

MAJOR BUYERS

As of March 31, Poland was the top buyer this year, purchasing 31 tonnes, followed by Uzbekistan (25 tonnes), Kazakhstan (13 tonnes) and China (7 tonnes), said Salim.

Central banks of the Czech Republic, Malaysia, Guatemala, Kyrgyz Republic, Cambodia, Indonesia and Serbia have also been net buyers.

Gold has rallied since 2024 due to hopes of interest rate cuts by banks, geopolitical crisis, trade disputes between the US and others, particularly China, and being seen as a strategic investment asset.

However, it has headed south since the Iran war broke out, as investors' fear of inflation, slack economic growth and soaring crude oil prices have led them to shift to the fossil fuel complex.

Gold, silver firm up on prospects of easing US-Iran tensions

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Gold prices jumped by ₹3,224 to ₹1,50,860 per 10 g against ₹147,636 on Tuesday on hopes of an early end to the ongoing West Asia war.

Silver prices jumped ₹8,602 to ₹2,49,067 a kg on expectations of higher demand.

The sharp recovery in bullion prices followed the prospects of a US-Iran peace agreement leading to softer dollar and oil prices.

This, in turn, will remove the two key headwinds that had weighed on bullion since the war began.

EASING TENSIONS

The yellow metal opened on a firm note at ₹1,50,636 per 10 g and gained further on easing geopolitical tensions and softer crude oil prices.

On the MCX, gold for June delivery was up 2 per cent at ₹1,52,601.

Similarly, silver for July delivery jumped 4 per cent to ₹254,152 a kg respectively.

Comex gold surged over 3 per cent to a one-week high of \$4,720 an ounce, while silver jumped nearly 6 per cent to \$77.87, its highest level in two weeks.

INFLATION RISKS EASE

Ajay Kumar, Director, Kedia Commodities, said, "The decline in oil prices helped ease inflation concerns, reducing expectations of aggressive monetary tightening."

"Earlier, gold faced strong selling pressure as elevated energy costs fuelled inflation fears and supported higher interest rate expectations," he added.

Kaynat Chainwala, AVP Commodity Research, Kotak Securities, said that with oil-linked inflation risks easing, the macro environment tilts modestly bullish for precious metals.

CACP moots raising ethanol price after sugarcane FRP hike

Vishwanath Kulkarni
Bengaluru

The Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices (CACP) has recommended revising ethanol prices derived from sugarcane-based feedstocks in line with the recent increase in the fair and remunerative price (FRP) of sugarcane.

It has also suggested exploring a dual pricing mechanism for sugar — separating domestic and commercial users — and proposed setting up a high-powered expert committee to review issues, such as cane area allocation and the revenue-sharing formula.

On Tuesday, the Cabinet

approved a ₹10 per quintal increase in FRP, taking it to ₹365 per quintal for the 2026-27 season, based on the CACP's recommendations.

In its non-price recommendations, the CACP observed that the administered price mechanism for ethanol produced from sugarcane-based feedstock and guaranteed procurement by the public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs) under the Ethanol Blended Petrol (EBP) Programme had helped in stabilising the Indian sugar sector and ensured timely cane payment to farmers.

"However, ethanol prices from sugarcane juice, sugar/syrup and B-heavy molasses have risen only marginally

over the past five years, compared with increases in sugarcane FRP and grain-based ethanol prices. The government should, therefore, revise ethanol prices from sugarcane-based feedstocks," the Commission said.

The recommendation assumes significance amid industry demands for an upward revision in ethanol prices.

DUAL PRICING

The CACP also suggested examining a dual pricing policy for sugar, noting that the industrial and commercial segments account for 60-65 per cent of domestic consumption. Several State governments and industry bodies have supported such a move.



PRICE RETHINK. The farm costs panel suggested examining a dual pricing policy for sugar, noting that the industrial segment accounts for 60-65% of domestic consumption

"Rapid expansion in capacity not accompanied by growth in cane availability and market demand for sugar has contributed to lower capacity utilisation and closure of over 30 per

cent of sugar factories in 2024-25 season," it said.

Further, it recommended that a high-powered expert committee, comprising key stakeholders, including Central and State govern-

Darjeeling first flush tea output rebounds after two weak years on improved weather

Mithun Dasgupta
Kolkata

The Darjeeling tea industry has heaved a sigh of relief as planters across the hills have reported a stronger crop for the premium first flush this year, aided by improved weather conditions.

Over the past two years, the industry suffered significant losses in high-value first flush output due to prolonged dry spells.

This year, however, overall production is expected to rise by around 30 per cent compared to last year.

BETTER CROP

"The first flush has been better this year — much improved over the last two, which were exceptionally bad. Weather conditions have been more favourable this time," Anshuman Kanoria, Chairman of the Indian Tea Exporters Association, told *businessline*.



TURNAROUND. In the last two years, the industry suffered significant losses in the high-value first flush teas due to prolonged dry spells

The first flush crop, harvested in the Darjeeling hills and regarded as the world's most expensive tea, accounts for about 20 per cent of the region's annual production.

Owing to its premium quality and pricing, it contributes nearly 40 per cent of total revenues for producers.

Plucking of the first flush, which marks the start of the new season, typically begins in mid-March and concludes by end-April.

HIGHER OUTPUT SEEN

"Crop-wise, the first flush has been good. Almost every garden has received ad-

equated rainfall this time, leading to higher yields across the board. The overall first flush output is expected to increase by around 30 per cent year-on-year," said Himangshu Kumar Shaw, owner of the Giddapahar Tea Estate.

Darjeeling tea production is highly dependent on rainfall and favourable weather, which directly influence both the quantity and quality of the first flush — the most prized harvest of the season.

Production had dipped below 6 million kg in 2024, with output at 5.6 million kg. It declined further to 5.3 million kg last year, marking one of the lowest levels in recent history. In overseas markets, annual shipments of Darjeeling tea typically range between 3 and 3.25 million kg, with Europe and Japan remaining key destinations.

Notably, Darjeeling tea was the first product in India to receive a geographical indication tag.

Go long on copper futures

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

Copper prices have been consolidating over the past three weeks.

The copper futures contract traded on the MCX has been oscillating between ₹1,255 and ₹1,305 per kg.

Within the range, the price has been moving up over the last couple of days. The contract is currently trading at ₹1,300.

COMMODITY

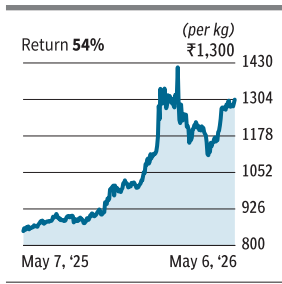
CALL.

The near-term outlook is positive. The recent rise seems to be having strength. A rise to ₹1,320 looks likely in the coming days. The price action thereafter will need a close watch.

Failure to breach ₹1,320 and a reversal thereafter could drag the contract down to ₹1,290-1,280 again.

On the other hand, if the contract manages to breach ₹1,320 decisively, it could gain momentum.

Such a break could then



take the contract up to ₹1,360 and even higher, going forward. The overall trend is up. The recent sideways move is just a consolidation within that.

As such, we see high chances for the contract to break ₹1,320 and resume the broader uptrend.

TRADE STRATEGY

Traders can go long now at ₹1,300. Accumulate on dips at ₹1,285. Keep the stop-loss at ₹1,270. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹1,308 as soon as the contract goes up to ₹1,318.

Revise the stop-loss higher to ₹1,315 and ₹1,325 when the contract touches ₹1,325 and ₹1,335, respectively. Exit at ₹1,340.

‘61% chance of El Nino emerging before July’

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Though El Nino-Southern Oscillation (ENSO) neutral conditions are favoured to continue through to June, there is a 61 per cent chance of drought-bearing El Nino emerging between May and July, the Climate Prediction Center (CPC) of the US has said.

In its May 4 update on the ENSO status, the CPC, an arm of the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), said that from early February, above-average sea surface temperatures (SSTs) had emerged in the far-eastern equatorial Pacific.

"Since mid-April 2026, near-to-above average SSTs expanded across most of the

equatorial Pacific Ocean."

This raises concerns for Asia, particularly India, as El Nino could impact the South-West monsoon rainfall.

The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast a below-normal monsoon this year, with the rainfall being 92 per cent of the long-period average.

2023 IMPACT

In 2023, when the El Nino emerged, India received only 94 per cent of LPA rainfall, leading to drought and prolonged dry periods in over one-third of the country. It affected the production of key kharif crops such as oilseeds, pulses and paddy.

Earlier this month, the IMD said El Nino could last at least until January 2027, raising concerns over rabi

The IMD said that El Nino may persist till early 2027, threatening rabi sowing

sowing that begins in October. In addition, storage in major reservoirs is currently below 40 per cent of capacity.

The CPC said that over the past two months, above-average subsurface temperatures had strengthened in the east-central and eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean. At the same time, westerly wind anomalies emerged in the eastern and east-central Pacific Ocean in mid-to-late April.

SUPER EL NINO THREAT

It said the recent value of the

Relative Ocean Nino Index (RONI) during April-February was -0.5°C, which means that La Nina continued.

However, the transition to ENSO neutral has taken place.

While predicting the onset of El Nino this year, global weather agencies warned of a super El Nino, which could be more severe.

El Nino could surpass the intensity of the 2023 event and rival the formidable episode of 2015, according to Swadhin Behera, Director of the Application Research Laboratory at the Japan Agency for Marine-Earth Science and Technology.

For India and other countries in Asia, a sliver of hope is that the Indian Ocean Dipole could emerge and probably limit the impact of the drought-bearing weather.

Apeda to hold basmati survey on 4 million hectares

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Jitin Prasada, Minister of State for Commerce, unveiled last week India's first AI-based basmati paddy survey (2026-2028), an initiative to be implemented by Apeda across nearly 4 million hectares.

The scale has sparked industry debate. The Agricultural and Processed Food Products Export Development Authority's (Apeda) own 2023 report had pegged the basmati cultivation area as 2.14 million hectares — roughly half the proposed coverage.

The gap has revived discussions on a possible expansion of the Basmati Geographical Indication (GI) zone, even as the inclusion of Madhya Pradesh remains *sub*



judice. By deploying AI over a wider geography, the government appears to be preparing for broader mapping of aromatic rice production, despite unresolved legal and regional boundaries of the traditional basmati belt.

Concerns have also been raised over collaboration with a particular industry

body, whose representative is a board member of the Basmati Export Development Foundation (BEDF), given that the project is to be funded from the BEDF corpus.

Apeda currently levies ₹70 per tonne on exporters for mandatory contract registration to fund the corpus.

Per the government, the survey will cover about 4 million hectares, collect data from over 1,50,000 ground-truth points and engage more than 5,00,000 farmers. It aims to enable precise crop assessment, varietal identification, scientific advisories and improved export planning.

NON-GI AREAS

Industry sources said Apeda conducted annual basmati surveys until kharif 2023 (except during the pandemic) but discontinued them in

2024 amid pressure from some exporters.

The agency tasked with the survey was also asked to include non-GI areas but declined, citing legal restrictions on classifying such produce as basmati. Queries sent to Apeda remained unanswered.

The Indian Rice Exporters' Federation (IREF) said it had not yet been approached for collaboration but is keen to participate.

"We plan to approach Apeda for joint collaboration as a structured crop survey is central to well-informed policy decisions," said Vinod Kaul, Director-General, IREF, adding that reliable production data could emerge only from a comprehensive survey.

The IREF, however, supports surveying non-GI areas as well.



SOLID घर
सिर्फ
BANGUR
CEMENT



Shree Cement Limited

Regd. Office : Shree Cement Ltd., Bangur Nagar, Beawar-305901, Rajasthan | Phone: 01462 228101-6 | Fax: 01462 228117/119 | E-mail: shreebwr@shreecement.com | Website: www.shreecement.com | CIN: L26943RJ1979PLC001935

EXTRACT OF CONSOLIDATED AUDITED FINANCIAL RESULTS FOR THE QUARTER AND YEAR ENDED ON 31ST MARCH, 2026

₹ in Crore

		Quarter ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)	Year ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)
1	Total Income from Operations	6202.16	21604.30	5689.95	19872.05
2	Net Profit for the period before Taxes	666.94	2293.01	757.67	1311.51
3	Net Profit for the period after Taxes	527.53	1748.66	574.99	1123.80
4	Total Comprehensive Income for the period (Comprising Profit for the period after tax and other Comprehensive Income after tax)	765.39	2250.77	575.89	1209.90
5	Paid-up Equity Share Capital (Face value ₹ 10/- per share)	36.08	36.08	36.08	36.08
6	Reserves (excluding Revaluation Reserve)	23231.45	23231.45	21501.67	21501.67
7	Securities Premium Account	2408.63	2408.63	2408.63	2408.63
8	Net worth	23267.53	23267.53	21537.75	21537.75
9	Outstanding Debt	1593.72	1593.72	816.92	816.92
10	Debt-Equity Ratio (in times)	0.07	0.07	0.04	0.04
11	Earnings Per Share (of ₹ 10/- each) - (Not Annualized)				
	1. Cash (in ₹)	357.55	1247.83	368.30	1102.79
	2. Basic & Diluted (in ₹)	145.70	483.24	159.17	311.18
12	Capital Redemption Reserve	15.00	15.00	15.00	15.00
13	Debenture Redemption Reserve	-	-	-	-
14	Debt Service Coverage Ratio (in times)	26.64	25.03	8.07	9.81
15	Interest Service Coverage Ratio (in times)	26.64	25.03	38.42	22.07

Notes:

1. The above results were taken on record at the meeting of the Board of Directors held on 6th May, 2026.
2. Key Standalone Financial Information:-

₹ in Crore

PARTICULARS	Quarter ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Year ended 31.03.2026 (Audited)	Quarter ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)	Year ended 31.03.2025 (Audited)
Total Income from operations	5755.16	19907.35	5390.27	18614.49
Net Profit for the period before Taxes	670.08	2248.44	742.77	1397.37
Net Profit for the period after Taxes	531.99	1706.25	555.98	1196.23

3. The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under regulations 33 & 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended. The full format of the standalone and consolidated financial results for the quarter and year ended 31st March, 2026 are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the company website viz. www.shreecement.com. The results can also be accessed by scanning the **Quick Response Code** given below.

4. For the other line items referred in regulation 52(4) of the Listing Regulations, pertinent disclosures have been made to the Stock Exchanges (www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com) and on the company website viz. www.shreecement.com.



Place: Kolkata
Date: 6th May, 2026
For details e-mail at : subhash.jajoo@shreecement.com

By order of the Board
For SHREE CEMENT LIMITED

(H.M. Bangur)
Chairman
DIN: 00244329

